escapism

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30785318.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra Character Study (She-Ra), a singing cat, manifesting a catra song if we ever get a movie bc i think we deserve it, Pre-Canon, Post-Canon, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, a little bit of hurt/comfort, Fluff, angst but nothing we don't see in the show, shadow weaver's spectacular parenting skills but again nothing more than in the show

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by adoras_braincell

Summary

in which quite literally everything is the same except Catra sings "Escapism" from Steven Universe

also...a deep look at the inner psyche of a catgirl

Notes

This was inspired by a tiktok I saw that I cannot find again for the life of me. If I ever do come across it, I will add it here. In the meantime, if you are the one who made a tiktok that said "Imagine Season 5 Catra singing Escapism on Prime's ship" I want you to know that the idea got stuck in my head and this fic is the result.

See the end of the work for more notes

Something is on fire inside of Catra. Her tail bushes uncontrollably, breaths coming in uneven gasps as she curls herself into the smallest corner of the box she had been hiding, been *left* in when the soldiers came.

"We found her during the raid, my lord," one of the soldiers is saying now.

The man on the throne looks down at the two soldiers, one of whom is carrying a battered and burned looking box. He rises, descending the steps of his throne and takes the box, lifting the flap and peering inside.

Catra looks up to see a pair of red, terrifying eyes glaring down at her. She begins to cry, a pathetic mewling sound escaping from her mouth. The man's eyes narrow and he thrusts the box back into the soldier's hands.

"Get it out of my sight."

The soldiers bow and turn from the throne. The box is jostled as they walk and Catra flattens herself against the bottom to avoid being tossed around.

"Should we bring her to the nursery?"

"Nah, let's leave her here. You know that old sorceress likes to keep tabs on all the kids that come into the Fright Zone."

The soldier carrying the box stops and places it on the floor. He gives it a kick with his boot and sends it sliding across the floor into a room off the main corridor. Catra flails and the motion knocks the box onto its side, forcing her to scramble back to avoid tumbling out. One of the flaps had fallen down obscuring her view of this new room but Catra doesn't need to see it to know that she doesn't like it. It's smelly, it's dark and it's *loud* , the constant mechanical and metallic drone grating on her sensitive ears. She flattens them against her head and pulls her knees close.

Something clatters against the floor on the other side of the box. Catra's tail bushes out even more as she picks up the sound of footsteps moving quickly towards her. The panic inside Catra blazes, threatening to choke her as a pair of red and white shoes appear in her line of sight. Catra squeezes her eyes shut.

"Hi!" says a voice. Catra opens one eye to see a girl, as small as she is, on her hands and knees peering into the box. Catra opens her other eye and stares.

Bright. Everything about this girl is bright. Bright blue eyes, bright blonde hair, bright toothy smile…

"I'm Adora! Want to be my friend?" The girl stretches one hand toward Catra who hisses and draws back further into the box.

The girl drops her hand quickly but doesn't back away. Instead, she shifts, sitting cross legged, her ponytail just brushing the top of the box. She looks at Catra and tilts her head to one side.

"Are you scared? Being scared is a tactical weakness." She says it haltingly, like the words are too big for her mouth.

Catra watches her for a moment, watches those big blue eyes and how they seem to be analyzing Catra as if creating a battle map of her most vulnerable points. Then she blinks and the feeling disappears.

"What's a tactile weakness?" Catra finally says in a quiet voice.

"I don't really know but Shadow Weaver says it a lot," the girl shrugs. "Hey, do you wanna pretend your box is a bot and we can battle it?"

A part of Catra wants to stay here, cowering in the back of the box but something about the girl has snuffed out the fiery panic that's been burning since the soldiers came so when she stretches her hand out again, Catra takes it and crawls from the box.

The room is smaller than Catra had imagined, most of it dominated by a large, dark runestone in the center. The girl picks up a metal staff, taller than both of them and presses a button on the center. There is a click and the staff splits in half. The girl hands one of the halves to Catra and turns to the box.

"Enemy coming from the woods!" she yells charging forward. "Assume attack positions!"

Catra watches her launch herself at the box, striking the side with her staff. She tumbles to the floor dramatically, yelling about a blaster.

"You have to take out the blaster before it takes out our entire squadron!" The girl looks expectantly at Catra who just stands there, unsure how to move. Slowly the girl stands up and comes over, leaving her staff on the floor.

"The blaster is on top of the bot." She spreads Catra's hands out on the staff. "You can hold it better now. I'll distract the bot while you jump on top and take out the blaster."

She returns to her staff, and shouts, "over here!" and launches into a flurry of strikes against the side of the box. Glancing over at Catra she calls, "now! Jump now!"

After a brief moment of hesitation, Catra jumps, bringing her staff down on top of the box, the force of the strike vibrating up her arms. The girl cheers and Catra finds herself smiling. She leaps down and comes to stand next to the girl. They both charge forward and spend several minutes screeching with glee as they land strike after strike on the box.

"You have to try it like this," the girl shows her another move, jumping to the side and swinging her staff out in a large arc as she does. Catra mimics her, the tip of her staff glancing off the side of the box.

"Enemy defeated!" the girl whoops, grabbing Catra's arm as she jumps up and down. Catra giggles and raises her staff in victory.

“Adora,” comes a quiet, harsh voice from behind them. The girl – Adora – startles, dropping her staff to the ground. Catra turns in time to see the shadows in the corner darken, condensing into the figure of a woman. She moves forward, the shadows curling off her like smoke and in the harsh light Catra can see that she is floating several inches off the ground, her hair rippling upwards, her entire face covered by an intimidating, emotionless mask.

It is somehow not the strangest thing Catra has seen since the soldiers came but she takes a half-step back behind Adora anyway.

“You know you are not allowed in my sanctum, child.” The woman crouches before Adora who seems to stand up straighter.

“I was playing with my new friend!” Adora moves aside and the woman’s eyes flick to Catra for the first time. They linger for a moment before returning to Adora but whatever they see is unreadable behind the mask.

“Her box was a bot and we were battling with it and she did a good job blocking blasts for me,” Adora continues. She stops suddenly and faces Catra, eyebrows furrowed together. “Oh…I forgot. What’s your name?”

“Catra” she whispers, glancing at the woman in front of them. Adora smiles and Catra feels a smile of her own spread across her face.

“Catra is my friend.” Adora turns back to the woman. “Can she stay, Shadow Weaver?”

The fire in Catra’s chest has cooled into something pleasantly warm at Adora’s words. She can’t remember ever having a friend before and she likes the way it sounds.

“Perhaps.” Shadow Weaver stands and places a hand on Adora’s head. “But you have training and I expect you to perform as well as you did yesterday. Perhaps, if you continue to improve, you’ll impress even Lord Hordak himself.”

Adora’s eyes widen, “really?”

“Off you go,” and Adora runs off, stopping briefly at the door to wave to Catra. The room suddenly feels a little bigger and darker without her and Catra shivers as she glances up at Shadow Weaver.

“Unlike Adora, you have no power.” She says it simply, just an observation, but Catra feels the weight of shame spread throughout her limbs. “However, you have potential. I saw you playing together and with training perhaps you could be of service to the Horde.”

Catra’s ears flatten as Shadow Weaver crouches again. She wraps her arms around herself as Shadow Weaver continues.

“I can make you stronger. Without me, you’ll be thrown into the nursery, lost among the other pitiful children who have no power. Forgotten.” The shadows creep towards Catra with every word.

“I want to be stronger,” Catra says, willing her voice not to shake.

Shadow Weaver places her hands on either side of Catra’s head and there is a crackling sound as the large stone in the center of the room glows red with power. Catra tries to pull away but finds herself frozen in place, the red glow surrounding her as well.

“Then your training begins now.”

……

Catra is shoved into a room lined with bunks of restless children. She is directed towards a bed at the end of the row, near the door. On the right, a nervous looking boy with blonde hair sits chatting with some kind of humanoid lizard that Catra has never seen the likes of before. On the left, the bed is empty and looks as though it was clumsily made.

She is given a pair of grey pajamas to change into and leaves her clothes in a pile next to her bed as she climbs in. The boy and the

lizard glance at her briefly but don't say anything which is fine by Catra. She sits, drawing her knees up to her chest and glancing around the room. Many of the children in here seem to be slightly older and bigger than her and most are laughing, teasing their neighbors though a few near the other end already appear to be asleep.

"Lights out in one minute" announces a voice from an overhead speaker. The laughing fades as children make their way to the beds. The lizard stands and ruffles the boy's hair before heading to his own bed on the other side of the room. Catra's gaze follows him before she realizes someone is staring at her.

"Why are you looking at me?" She turns to the boy beside her, who blushes and quickly looks away.

"Nothing. S-sorry." He stammers. "I've never seen you before. Are you new? I'm Kyle by the way."

"Catra" she replies, pulling the thin blanket over her. "Who was that?"

Kyle glances in the direction of the lizard and smiles, "oh that's Rogelio! He's been helping me learn the material for my tactical geography course. There's an exam coming up and I need to do really well to stay with my cohort."

The lights go out before Catra has a chance to respond. She wiggles further under the blanket and stares up at the ceiling waiting for sleep to come but it doesn't. All around her, the noises of the other children fade into deep breathing and the occasional snore.

The bed is hard, the mattress lumpy and Catra spends several minutes tossing around trying to get comfortable. Nothing feels right and the blanket is scratchy on her skin as she curls onto her side and sniffs, feeling tears prick at the corners of her eyes. She buries her face in the pillow but it smells wrong and suddenly it is

all too much for Catra and she begins to cry again, kicking the blanket off in frustration.

The lights remain off, the children closest to her stirring slightly in their sleep as she sobs. Catra struggles to take a deep breath but her chest is too tight and the tears flow freely down her face. She tries to call out for someone but she doesn't know who would come. Someone used to come when she cried or at least she thinks someone did but everything, all of her memories, from before the room with Shadow Weaver have become fuzzy and indistinct.

Sometime later, the door creaks open, the light from the corridor thrown across Catra's bed and she hastily pulls the blanket up over her face. Footsteps, fast and light, make their way close to Catra's bed and she hears a familiar voice whisper, "Catra?"

She lowers the blanket to see Adora in a matching pair of pajamas standing next to her bed, head cocked in concern.

"Why are you sad?" Adora whispers.

"The blanket is scratchy" Catra whispers back tearfully.

Adora glances at her own blanket, lost in thought for a moment before she looks back at Catra. "Mine is scratchy too but I still like it."

Catra sniffs, rubbing a hand across her eyes and when she looks up again, Adora is right in front of her, arms raised. She leans forward and wraps them around Catra who stiffens at the touch before relaxing into it, overwhelmed by the sudden sense of safety she feels. They stay like that for several minutes before Adora releases her and climbs into her own bed. She curls on her side facing Catra and watches as she adjusts the blanket over her once more. She keeps watching as Catra flips around before finally finding a position that is comfortable and it is not until her eyes have finally drifted shut and her breathing grows slow and even that Adora rolls on to her stomach and closes her own eyes.

In the morning, both girls are shaken awake by Shadow Weaver. Catra sits up, blinking heavily while Adora leaps out of bed almost immediately.

"You are both to report to the training room after breakfast." Shadow Weaver is saying, waiting only for a nod from Adora before leaving.

Adora and Catra dress quickly, Catra pulling on the clothes she was wearing yesterday. They are rumpled from the night on the floor and she can't help but glance at Adora's pristine white and red shirt as she brushes some dirt off her pants. They step into the hallway and Catra comes to the realization that she had no idea where to go next.

Adora realizes it too only a moment later. "C'mon" she says, taking Catra's hand and leading her through a series of corridors to the mess hall. In time, Catra will discover shortcuts, roundabout ways of navigating the Fright Zone and develop an impressive ability to navigate the ventilation system but for now her head spins as she tries to pick out landmarks to remember their progress.

Shadow Weaver is waiting for them when they arrive at the training room. "You'll be training with Force Captain Octavia today," she says leading them inside.

A formidable looking woman steps forward, holding a long training staff in each hand. With a shock, Catra realizes there are four green tentacles sprouting from under her arms, each holding a pair of goggles and a metallic breastplate. She thrusts the armor at Catra, smirking at her confusion when Catra stares at it. The room suddenly feels very hot and Catra's eyes flick over to Adora who is clipping herself into the armor with practiced ease.

"You should already be dressed," Octavia's voice sends a shiver up Catra's spine.

"Adora, show her the correct way to put her armor on," Shadow Weaver says, heading over to a low bench in the corner, pulling

out a beeping tablet as she sits. “We don’t have all day.”

Adora gently takes the armor out of Catra’s hands. “It’s okay,” she whispers. “It’s super tricky the first time.”

Swiftly she buckles Catra into the armor and hands her one of the staffs. Octavia spends over an hour demonstrating various offensive and defensive moves which she has Catra and Adora repeat until they do them flawlessly. Then she presses up a button on the control panel and a section of the back wall slides open revealing two large bots.

“Team up,” Octavia orders with a wicked grin.

Catra would have been pulverized if Adora hadn’t been there. She flies into action, leaping in front of Catra and taking out the first bot’s blaster almost immediately. The second bot is not so easily incapacitated. It charges forward, effectively splitting them up. Catra finds herself facing the rear while Adora charges the front, attempting a similar maneuver to take out the blaster. The bot swivels and Adora’s staff clatters against its body with a hollow clang. The good news is that she lands on her feet, no longer facing the direct threat of the blaster.

The bad news is that the blaster is now pointed at Catra.

“Block the blast!” Adora yells.

Catra is glued to the spot, her tail completely bushed out in terror. A humming noise comes from the bot and Catra raises her staff at the absolute last second, managing to deflect the blast back towards the bot’s legs. One leg is knocked off and the bot skitters, suddenly unbalanced.

“You’ve got it!” Adora has used the momentary distraction to close the distance, her shoulders brushing Catra’s as she comes up next to her. “It’s wobbly so it’s blaster will have a hard time locking on to targets.”

“Okay,” Catra hates how shaky her voice sounds and her chest is burning with barely controlled panic.

“Dive!” Adora orders with way more command in her voice than someone her age should ever have. The bot stumbles toward them and Adora throws herself to the side, bringing her full weight down on the joint of one of the bot’s remaining legs. It buckles, sending the bot crashing to the ground. As it falls, Catra leaps straight up, reminded of the game she and Adora played yesterday with her box.

She brings her staff down on the blaster, the shock knocking her staff clean out of her hands. The blaster tumbles to the ground, stopping at Catra’s feet and the bot beeps once before going still.

“Catra!” Adora crashes into her, knocking her to the ground as she flings her arms around her. “You defeated the bot!”

Giddy relief sweeps through Catra as she sits up, laughing with Adora.

“Not bad,” Octavia admits. “If you were attempting to put your entire squadron at risk that is.”

Adora draws herself up, glaring at Octavia. “Catra took out a whole bot. The mission was a success because of her.” She barely comes up to the Force Captain’s waist but her voice is laced with a defiance that makes Shadow Weaver float over, placing a hand on Adora’s shoulder. At her touch, Adora blinks, the fire disappearing from her face replaced by a look of caution as she tries to gauge Shadow Weaver’s reaction.

“Perhaps we should see how she does in interpersonal combat.” Shadow Weaver suggests.

Octavia grunts and turns to the control panel on the wall. She enters a series of commands and the floor underneath the bots glows red, opening with a metallic groan and sending the bots tumbling into the depths below.

Shadow Weaver returns to her bench and Octavia instructs them to stand in the center of the room.

“First one disarmed wins.”

They face each other, hesitation scrawled across both their features.

“Adora,” Shadow Weaver warns from her seat. Adora glances over and then back at Catra. She steps forward and gives a slow swipe of her staff that Catra has no trouble dodging.

“ *Adora.* ”

Adora flashes Catra an apologetic look and Catra barely blocks her next strike. They trade parries back and forth for a minute, each getting a feel for the other’s rhythm. But Adora has more training and the staff feels clunky in Catra’s hands, her arms already aching from the fight with the bots. Adora quickly overpowers her, knocking the staff out of her hands with a few well executed strikes.

Shadow Weaver seems satisfied and praises Adora’s technique. She says nothing about Catra and dismisses them both with a wave of her hand.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks once they are away from the training room.

Catra nods and Adora gently bumps her arm with her shoulder.

“You really were awesome in there.”

They smile at each other and take off running down the corridor, shoulders jostling as they both try to be the first one to the end.

As she crawls into bed that night, Catra thinks she is too exhausted to cry but as soon as the lights go out she feels her chest grow tight and her eyes start to burn. She tries to take a deep breath but it comes out as more of a hiccup. There is a

creaking noise and she feels the mattress dip as Adora climbs next to her.

“Have you ever heard of the Weeping Princess?” Adora asks.

Catra shakes her head.

“Well, she’s a vengeful spirit who roams Etheria looking for victims.” Adora lowers her voice and Catra leans in to hear the rest of the story. “You know she’s coming for you by the sound of weeping right before she strikes.”

“Really?” Catra breathes.

Adora nods, her face serious. “Shadow Weaver told me.”

“What else did she tell you about?”

There’s silence for a moment, while Adora thinks. She shifts, rolling on her side so she is facing Catra, their noses almost touching.

“Did you ever hear about Beast Island?”

…….

It goes on like this, training during the day with Shadow Weaver and whispering together in the barrack at night. Eventually, Catra joins Adora in class, learning how to read and write battle plans and field reports. After four months, Catra begins to show some improvement, actually getting in a few hits during training. After seven months, even Shadow Weaver has to admit that she is nearing Adora’s level of skill.

After a year, she finally beats Adora, using her staff to knock her feet out from under her before pinning her to the ground.

“That was awesome Catra!” Adora beams.

“You should not have been defeated,” Shadow Weaver places a hand on Catra’s arm and firmly pulls her off Adora. “You were distracted. There is no room for distraction when facing an enemy.”

“Catra’s not my enemy,” Adora sits up, head tilted to the side as she looks at Shadow Weaver. “She’s my best friend.”

“She is your enemy in training and you let your feelings cloud your judgment.”

Adora glances at Catra and she can see her own uncertainty mirrored in her friend’s face.

“The battle was only over because you decided it was,” Shadow Weaver continues. “Had you been focused you would have seen your enemy leave an opening that you could have used to your advantage.”

She releases Catra’s arm and gestures towards Adora. “Show me how you would overpower an enemy who has you pinned down.”

“But –”

“It was not a question, Adora.”

A look of quiet resignation passes across Adora’s face and she lays back, nodding at Catra who reluctantly presses her staff across her arms, using her legs to pin Adora’s chest down.

“Now,” Shadow Weaver commands.

In a single, swift movement, Adora swings both legs up, knocking Catra off balance using the change in momentum to toss the staff to the side and pushing her to the ground. Her hands come up, pinning her arms to the ground while her legs straddle Catra’s thighs, effectively preventing her from using her legs to overpower Adora.

“Excellent Adora.” Shadow Weaver nods in satisfaction. “I trust you will not allow yourself to be lost to distraction again.”

“No, Shadow Weaver,” Adora says quietly. She won’t meet Catra’s eyes as she releases her and helps her up.

“You are dismissed.” Adora wraps one arm around Catra’s shoulders and leads them into the corridor.

“I didn’t mean to get you in trouble,” Catra says apologetically once the door swishes shut behind them.

Adora shakes her head, “it’s my fault. Shadow Weaver said I was distracted.”

“You didn’t seem distracted.”

“Next time, I’ll just have to be better,” Adora finally glances over at Catra and there is something like fear in her expression. “You really were awesome though. I’ve never seen you use that move before and you got it perfect!”

Catra feels her face grow hot at the praise. They’ve arrived at the mess hall and are given their allowed ration bars.

“Here,” Adora says, cutting off part of her bar and handing it to Catra. “I know you like the grey kind.”

They’ve barely taken a couple of bites when an older cadet, one Catra doesn’t recognize, appears before them.

“Is one of you Adora?”

Adora raises her hand, ration bar crumbs stuck to her chin.

“Shadow Weaver wants to see you. Like right now.”

Catra looks over at Adora. Her brow is furrowed and she shoves the rest of the ration bar in her mouth, brushing the crumbs off her hands as she stands.

“Coming,” she says to the older cadet. Turning to Catra, she gives her a reassuring smile. “I’ll see you later!”

She follows the older cadet out of the mess hall and Catra finishes her ration bar in silence. She makes her way back to the barracks and crawls into her bed to wait for Adora.

She hasn’t returned by the time the lights go out and Catra curls up under the blanket, trying and failing to fight the exhaustion that always overtakes her after a long day of training.

A nightmare startles her awake a short time later. Usually, she would climb into Adora’s bunk and listen to her tell stories about the Horde or they would just talk but Adora’s bed is still empty. Suddenly the dark shapes of the other bunks seem much more menacing and Catra squirms underneath her blanket. She starts to hum quietly to herself, something to distract herself from the creepy, creaking noises that filter through the Fright Zone at night.

As she settles back down, she realizes the song she is humming seems familiar but she can’t remember ever hearing it before. She drifts back to sleep and when she wakes in the morning, Adora is back and the song is pushed from Catra’s mind completely.

“Hey Adora!” she chirps sitting up and swinging her legs off the side of the bed.

“Hey,” Adora sounds exhausted. There are deep circles under eyes that suggest she came back very late. As she pulls her shirt on, Catra notices several deep bruises on her arms and legs. Bruises that definitely were not there the day before.

“Are you okay?” Catra asks, hopping down from her bunk and coming to stand next to Adora.

She glances down at the bruises and something flashes across her face, too quick for Catra to register. “I had to do some extra training last night.” Adora shrugs unable to fully stop herself from wincing as she does. “I’m fine though.”

Catra isn't sure she believes her but she lets it go all the same. Mostly because Adora won't answer any of her questions about what kind of extra training and why does she need extra training when Shadow Weaver so clearly thinks Catra is the one with room to improve.

They head to breakfast and then training together like they do every day. Most of their days follow the same schedule and they still find themselves gravitating towards one another on the days that don't. They become like shadows within the Horde, one always trailing after the other. Or perhaps they are more like magnets, drawn together and made an unbreakable unit by some invisible force. The other children pick up on it and so does Shadow Weaver. She begins to schedule more separate trainings, with Adora reporting to her at least three nights a week for additional training. Catra still isn't sure why Adora needs the extra training when she is the one being constantly reminded of her weaknesses in battle. Little by little, she improves enough that it becomes harder for Shadow Weaver to find something to critique her on.

Not that she doesn't try, of course.

On the nights when Adora doesn't have training, they sit together on one of their bunks, talking and telling stories, planning pranks and their futures until the early hours of the morning. When she is not there, Catra often finds herself humming the same song, a lilting melody that stirs some of her earliest memories.

Sometimes if she strained her memory enough she could hear the melody coming from someone else, threading itself between bad dreams and the haze of a fever. The barest touch of a cool hand on her skin. But it was always so hazy that Catra was almost positive she had dreamed it. She would remember if someone, if an adult, had taken care of her like that.

Wherever the melody came from, Catra hums it until she falls asleep, eventually realizing she can't remember why she used to cry at night.

.....

There is a spot on the roof that is just theirs. They sit back-to-back, knees drawn up as they work on their respective assignments – Adora drafting a battle plan for a two-team mission into the Whispering Woods and Catra analyzing a field report of a failed siege on the castle at Bright Moon. A warm breeze snatches one of Catra's papers from her lap but Adora catches it, handing it back with a smile that makes Catra's face grow hot. Adora doesn't seem to notice as she turns back to her work.

She hadn't realized she was humming until Adora asks, "what are you singing?"

"Huh?" Catra flags an error in squadron formation on her report before turning to look at Adora.

"What's that song you're humming?" She gathers up her papers, placing them into a file at her feet. Without looking over, she holds out a hand and Catra gives her the reports she was working on. "It's always the same one." Adora adds Catra's work into the file with her own.

"Oh, um…" Some part of Catra recoils in shame, expecting to be punished. She's not entirely sure music is allowed in the Fright Zone – certainly, she's never heard any in the nearly five years she's been here.

But it's Adora asking, so genuinely curious about everything, that Catra feels safe telling her, "I don't really know. It's always just been in my head, I guess."

"I like it," Adora says, gently nudging Catra with her shoulder and that is all Catra needs to hear. The song is Adora's now as much as it is Catra's.

They gather up their belongings and head to their afternoon training session. As always, Adora is chosen as the mission leader, this time for a simulated attack in the icy mountains of the kingdom of Snows.

It goes wrong almost immediately. It's a rare thing for Adora to fail in a mission and usually Shadow Weaver will blame it on the minor mistakes of one of her teammates, gently admonishing Adora for not being more focused. This time, Catra watches Adora falter, leading them into an ambush and stumbling over attack formations and even Shadow Weaver can't find anyone else to blame it on.

"Your distraction meant the defeat of your entire squadron." Shadow Weaver's voice is cold, disappointed and Catra notices Adora shrink at the sound. "You forgot your most basic training and you *failed.* "

"I –" Adora's voice trembles. "I'm sorry Shadow –"

Their mentor holds up a hand silencing her. Turning to the rest of the cadets, she orders them to leave. Catra lingers, seeing the desperate look on Adora's face.

"Why are you still here, cadet?" Shadow Weaver stares down at Catra.

"I thought I could –"

In an instant, the darkness condenses around them and Shadow Weaver swells to three times her normal size.

"LEAVE" she bellows and Catra stumbles back. Two small hands grab her arm and she feels Adora shove her towards the door.

"I don't want you getting in trouble," she whispers. The door slams shut and Catra hovers for a moment straining her ears to hear what is going on. Eventually, the thought of Shadow Weaver opening the door and finding her is enough to get her moving again and she heads to the locker room to change.

Adora doesn't appear at dinner or in the barracks afterward. The lights go out and Catra sits up, debating whether or not she should go look for her. Several times, her head droops but she shakes herself awake, eyes trained on the door.

The hours creep by, the smallest flame of worry starting to burn in Catra's stomach, when finally, the door creaks open. Catra rubs a hand across her eyes and whispers, "Adora?"

"It's me," comes the shaky reply. Adora turns to close the door and the light from the corridor illuminates the bruises already forming on her arms and the tears threatening to spill over from her eyes. She moves slowly to her bed, Catra's keen eyes following her in the dark and picking up on every wince that flashes across her face as she pulls on her pajamas.

"What happened?" she whispers.

Adora is quiet for a moment and Catra hears her take an unsteady breath before answering. "Shadow Weaver had me run some extra training sims. I can't make those kinds of mistakes again."

"Adora…"

"I'm okay Catra, I promise." But she is still moving so slowly, so gingerly as she pulls the blanket up and Catra can see her lying still on her back instead of curling on her side like she usually does. Adora's breathing is fast and uneven, a pathetic sniffling sound every few minutes until Catra crawls out of her bunk into Adora's. She presses herself against her friend, gently laying her tail across Adora's ankles as she curls towards her, burying her face in Catra's shoulder.

"Are you crying?"

"No," Adora murmurs but Catra can feel her shoulder growing damp.

"It's okay Adora, you just made one mistake!"

"It's NOT" Adora sobs. Several of the other children startle in their sleep and Adora's voice drops back to a whisper. "It's not okay Catra. The Rebellion takes advantage of those kinds of mistakes, they distract us and confuse us and then separate a squadron and they win and it's all my fault!"

"But it was just a training sim," Catra soothes. "It wasn't a real battle and you said you did extra training so now you know. So, it's…it's okay, right?"

Adora's voice low and guarded, "yeah…I got it perfect in the sims and I'll get it perfect out there too."

Something in her tone worries Catra. She knows that Shadow Weaver gives Adora extra training or has her train with the older cadets but Adora has never gone into detail about what actually happens during these sessions. Catra is old enough now to begin to question why things are the way they are in the Fright Zone and wonders what exactly Shadow Weaver considers "extra training."

The movement of Adora's hand pulls Catra out of her thoughts. She swipes furiously at her eyes and takes another trembling breath, reminding Catra of the nights after she first arrived in the Fright Zone and everything felt too big to understand and how she would hum to herself on the nights Adora wasn't there to talk with. She shifts slightly so that her head is resting on top of Adora's and begins to hum.

She feels, rather than hears, Adora's breathing become steadier and continues humming until the sniffling has stopped completely. Adora's breathing is still far too fast for her to be asleep so Catra picks up the song again, humming it over and over until she feels Adora's breaths become slower and deeper and she knows she is finally asleep.

…….

It becomes another one of their routines. Shadow Weaver decides to increase Adora's additional training to six nights a week, summoning her after dinner. Most nights, Adora comes back just after lights out, tired but happy to sit up whispering with Catra in her bunk until they both fall asleep. Some nights, she comes back later, shaking slightly from training and Catra knows

there will be new bruises in the morning. On these nights, Catra will crawl into Adora's bunk and hum until she falls asleep.

Rarely, Adora will come back after Catra is asleep. She'll be woken in the earliest hours of the morning to Adora thrashing around on her bed, breathing ragged and on these nights, Catra will wrap her tightly in her arms, humming until the thrashing stops and her breathing slows.

"Are there any words to the song?" Adora asks one day, a few weeks after they are both moved up to junior cadets. It's all planned out, a few more years and they'll be senior cadets and then after that, Force Captains.

Catra looks up from where she had been stretched out on the railing. Adora is leaning on her elbows, watching the smoke trailing out over the rooftops. "I don't think so. Why?"

"It might be kind of fun to add words." Adora says, almost to herself.

Catra sits up, hands wrapping around the railing to keep herself balanced. "What would the words be?"

"It could be about us! About the Horde and the Fright Zone," Adora's eyes light up in excitement. It occurs to Catra that she can't remember the last time Adora seemed this excited, only focused, determined to be the best in their class.

"Okay," Catra leaps down so she is standing next to Adora, elbows touching. "What about the Fright Zone?"

Adora's brow furrows as she thinks. After a moment she says, "Maybe it should start with something we hear all the time like… like –"

"Never show doubt!" they say simultaneously before collapsing into giggles. It's something their tactical maneuvers instructor says almost every single class.

“Never show doubt!” he roars, fist pounding his desk with every word. “Your enemies will exploit any weakness they can find and the best Horde soldiers are the ones who never doubt their Force Captains.” Something about his nasally voice and the way his chin wobbles when he talks forces Adora and Catra to shove their fists in their mouths to keep from laughing.

“Yes, let’s start with that” Adora says, letting out one final snort-like laugh that makes Catra’s heart stumble in her chest. “How do we fit it in?”

They toss out lines, each clunkier than the last as they try to fit it into the melody. After about five minutes, they lapse into a comfortable silence attempting to think of an option they haven’t tried. Catra sinks to the ground, legs dangling over the edge of the rooftop. As she gazes out over the Fright Zone, a line comes to her and she begins to sing slowly.

“ *I guess I have to face, that in this awful place, I shouldn’t show a trace of doubt.* ” She feels Adora lower herself to the ground next to her.

“That fits perfectly,” she says quietly.

They sit out on the roof for another hour but can’t come up with any more lyrics. Together they head over to the mess hall for dinner and afterwards, Adora heads off for her training with Shadow Weaver.

It becomes an inside joke, passed between them in murmurs during classes and whispers in the barracks at night. Once, after a particularly hard day of training for both of them, Catra sings it in the corridors as they cross through the Fright Zone.

“Shhhh!” Adora grabs her by the arm. “Sha- someone could hear you!”

Catra glances around. There are a couple of older senior cadets at the other end of the corridor but they are deep in a conversation and don’t even look up as the girls walk by. She’s not sure if the

rumors about Shadow Weaver being able to turn invisible and hear through walls are true but still, she doesn't want to risk getting Adora in any more trouble.

They are less than a year away from becoming senior cadets and Adora consistently ranks at the top of their class. She is publicly praised by Shadow Weaver almost every day, with promises of Lord Hordak's approval and a rank of Force Captain as soon as she is old enough.

Shadow Weaver, who hardly even looks at Catra anymore except to point out a mistake she makes in training. A mistake that brings her time down by mere seconds and doesn't even compromise the mission.

A frustration that Catra has long refused to acknowledge begins to grow until it is impossible not to look at. She knows it's not Adora's fault, knows she covers for her in class and in trainings. She also knows why Adora hesitates to speak up to their mentor and maybe it's not entirely fair but some of that frustration weaves itself into her feelings towards Adora when she bumps her stats up during training.

"There was an error with the clock. I kept track of everyone's times so I can enter them all manually at the end of the session." No one would dare contradict Shadow Weaver's protegee for fear of waking up and finding themselves demoted to border patrol. It shouldn't irritate Catra but she knows she can hold her own in training and that her stats are higher than what is expected of someone on the Force Captain track.

Still, it's Adora and Catra tries to tell herself none of this will matter anyway because soon, they'll be the ones calling the shots.

Both of them.

.....

Adora's promotion to Force Captain doesn't come as a surprise to Catra but Adora's hesitation does. This is what they've waited for and wanted their whole lives. Catra is practically bubbling with excitement, their dream of ruling the Fright Zone suddenly looking more like a reality, like a future than ever until it all comes crashing down as Adora says quietly, "Shadow Weaver says you're not coming."

Catra feels like she has been physically knocked backwards and a wave of fury towards their mentor crashes over her. A wave that's been building in her for longer than she can remember, maybe since that first day when Shadow Weaver looked at her and said she had no power as if *she* had any power that was her own.

She turns away from Adora, "I guess it sure must be easy being a people pleaser like you."

Adora is immediately on the defense. "I'm not a pe-" she begins and Catra is gone before she can even finish. She can hear Adora calling after her but she doesn't stop until she reaches a ladder that leads to the roof of one of the buildings in the Fright Zone. She scales it easily and paces the roof, ranting at everyone and no one.

Shadow Weaver and her dumb ideas about power and potential. Adora and that dumb wounded look on her face, like Catra's reaction disappointed her somehow as if Catra is not the one being left behind. And it's not like Catra even *wanted* to be a stupid Force Captain anyway but her time was just as good as Adora's and why can't *anyone* see that.

The fury in Catra quiets to a simmer by the time Adora arrives on the roof as Catra knew she would. She is apologetic and defensive at the same time and Catra feels herself growing irritated again even though she knows Adora is trying.

Catra is not an idiot. She knows what the warmth rushing through her chest, the way everything seemed to slow down and get brighter around Adora means. But still, does she always have to

get everything? And if she got everything she wanted was the real reason Catra wasn't going with her was because Adora didn't want her to?

"Do you think we'll ever be…" Catra begins in an attempt to distract herself from the fear that Adora didn't actually want her around.

"Free?" Adora finishes and there's that word again, *free.* Free from the Rebellion, free from the Fright Zone, free from distraction and Catra can hear Shadow Weaver's voice in her head again telling her all the ways she hold Adora back, all the times she should be grateful she was allowed to stay in the same cohort as Adora and Catra can't help but wonder if there is a part of Adora that agrees with Shadow Weaver. That she could be so much more without Catra. "Why do you ask?"

"Ugh, whatever" Catra rolls her eyes, afraid of where the conversation could go if she let it. "It's not like I even care. I just wanna get out of this dump at some point before I die of boredom."

She sighs turning back to the railing and gazes out over the rooftops, hazy from the smog, "I mean, I wonder what's even outside the Fright Zone anyway."

"Why don't we go find out" Adora replies after a moment in an uncharacteristically mischievous voice. Catra whips around to see her looking incredibly satisfied with herself, a key dangling from her hand.

…….

"I take it all back. You are officially awesome!'" Catra whoops as the skiff speeds through the Fright Zone. "I can't believe you actually stole a skiff!"

"Borrowed!" It's hard to miss the anxiety in Adora's voice and Catra feels a rush of affection knowing that Adora is only doing this for her . "Please don't make me regret this."

They hurtle towards the edge of the Fright Zone, Adora's face tight with worry, eyes narrowed in focus as she weaves the skiff around the buildings the line the outer edge of their home.

"I can't believe we are doing this" she murmurs to herself.

Without realizing it, Catra's fingers have begun to tap out a melody on the siderails of the skiff. It's the old, familiar melody, the one Catra still finds herself humming on Adora's more restless nights. She smirks and tilts her head back, Adora glancing over at her.

" *I guess I have to face that in this awful place, I shouldn't show a trace of doubt!* " Catra belts as loud as she can with the wind rushing in her face.

"Catra!" Adora hisses, slapping a hand over Catra's mouth. "Someone will hear you!"

A laugh bubbles up from Catra's throat. It is so ridiculously Adora to be worried about someone hearing her sing when they are very obviously flying a skiff towards the literal edge of their known world. She licks Adora's palm in retaliation and Adora cries out in surprise, pulling her hand away.

"Hey!" she pouts and Catra is bent over laughing at the expression on her face. Adora smiles despite herself, rolling her eyes as she returns her focus to the landscape in front of them, her face noticeably less tense than it was a moment ago.

The world is changing around them, bushes and trees beginning to overtake the mechanical structures that dominate the Fright Zone. The air feels cleaner too and the gloomy orange glow fades behind them. Adora pulls the skiff to a stop at the edge of a large, dark forest.

"What is it?" Catra asks, looking up at the trees.

"I think this must be the Whispering Woods." The anxiety has returned to Adora's voice and she glances around cautiously.

“They say there are strange old monsters in there and-and the trees move when you aren’t looking.”

She takes a half-step closer to Catra and drops her voice to a whisper, “every Horde squadron they’ve sent in there has never come out again.”

Catra looks back at the trees, “let’s go in.” She yanks the controller out of Adora’s hand and urges the skiff forward.

“Wait, what?” Adora yells, grabbing the siderails to keep herself from falling over as the skiff suddenly shoots forward. Catra whoops, laughing as they plunge deeper into the woods.

“Catra slow down!” Adora cries trying to take the controller from her. They fight over it for a moment before Adora glances up and her eyes widen. “Catra, tree! TREE!”

Catra turns and Adora uses the momentary distraction to take over the controller, jerking the skiff up towards the sky. Both girls are shouting when a vine catches Adora and knocks her out of the skiff.

“Adora!” Catra screams, frantically trying to turn the skiff around. She manages to bring it back to ground level and leaps out, charging into the bushes calling for Adora.

She finally finds her, spluttering about a sword that is nowhere to be seen. Catra feels the beginnings of panic begin to burn through her at the thought that Adora was seriously hurt and despite the very real threat of brain damage, Catra grabs her by the ponytail and drags her back to the skiff.

Adora lets Catra drive them out of the woods, taking control again once they reach the edge of the Fright Zone. They make it back to their barracks before lights out and as they pull on their pajamas, Catra notices that Adora’s hands are trembling.

Adora sees her looking and smiles, “I’m fine, Catra.”

But there is a faraway look in her eyes that tells Catra otherwise so instead of climbing into her own bed, she curls at the foot of Adora's, daring her to protest. She doesn't.

The lights go out and the mattress shifts, the bed creaking as Adora rolls from one side to the other trying to get comfortable. Catra lifts her head and glances around at the other cadets, confirming they are all still asleep, before beginning to hum the familiar tune to calm Adora. She hums it over and over until Adora finally goes still and her breathing evens out. Only then does Catra lay her head down and allow herself to go to sleep.

She's woken hours later in time to see the flash of Adora's ponytail disappearing into the corridor. Catra peers around the doorway to see her pulling her jacket on over her uniform.

"Hey, where are you going?"

Adora jumps and turns around. "Back to the woods," she whispers. "There's something I need to figure out."

"What?" Catra cannot believe she heard her right. "You're not-"

She's cut off as Adora covers her mouth and pulls her behind a ventilation shaft. A patrol bot rolls by, beeping softly.

"Are you sure you're not brain damaged?" Catra asks the minute Adora releases her, an uneasy feeling spreading throughout her stomach. Adora grabs her wrists, forcing her to step back.

"Look Catra, I know I saw something out there. It's ju-I just need to get another look." She spreads her hands in front of her. "It just feels important somehow."

Catra shrugs, "sounds good. Let's go."

"No." Adora holds out an arm to stop her. Her face softens and she places a hand on Catra's shoulder. "I don't want you getting in trouble on my behalf."

She turns to go and Catra suddenly finds herself growing frustrated with Adora for being an idiot like always and needing to go find some stupid sword that definitely doesn't exist and even if it did why does she *need* it when there are so many weapons in the Fright Zone's armory and…

The uneasy feeling grows and Catra wonders if Adora feels it too because she pauses for a moment and looks back.

"Just cover for me okay?" She gives Catra a soft smile. "I'll be back before anyone knows I'm gone!"

She disappears down the corridor and Catra can't stop herself from calling out as she does.

…….

Adora doesn't come back.

…….

There is talk of the new princess, the tall one with the sword.

Some of the rumors are believable, that she took out an entire Horde squadron by herself or that she lifted a tank with her bare hands.

Others just seem so outlandish, Catra can't understand how anyone believes them. Shooting lasers from her eyes, turning people to stone if you look directly at her.

Like, *come on.*

One thing the rumors seem to agree on is that no one knows who she is or where she came from and for reasons Catra can't admit to herself, she'd like to keep it that way.

The Horde is panicking.

“Oh please.” Catra scoffs in the locker room as Lonnie details yet again their embarrassing retreat at Thaymor. “She’s like every other princess: all sparkle, no substance. She caught us off-guard. That’s all.”

Lonnie rolls her eyes, “sure. You were the only one who saw her up close and you didn’t even land a hit on her.” She smirks, “did you freeze up?”

Catra unsheathes her claws but Lonnie doesn’t drop her gaze. “You think I’m scared of some *princess?* I could take her out whenever I want. I know her secret.”

“Oh yeah?” Lonnie crosses her arms, still not backing down. “And what is that?”

A low growl makes its way up Catra’s throat. “Like I’d tell you, *cadet* .”

“Easy, Catra. Adora’s not here to protect you anymore” Lonnie taunts. The locker room goes silent.

“Are you forgetting *I’m* Force Captain now?” Her voice is quietly dangerous. “I don’t need Adora to protect me. I never did.” She turns and storms out of the locker room before anyone can say anything.

The worst part of her promotion is having to attend meetings with Shadow Weaver.

“Force Captain Catra reporting for –” she stops as she takes in the footage on the monitor. Several Horde squadrons are in full retreat, their camp in flames behind them – and were those *vines* climbing over the tanks?

“This was brought to me by retreating soldiers,” Catra is pretty sure Shadow Weaver is making herself appear taller as she looms over her. “Retreating because their camp was attacked by Adora and She – Ra.”

Panic flickers through Catra momentarily but she shoves it aside, keeping her face as neutral as possible. She glances back at the footage and is convinced Adora really did suffer brain damage that night in the Whispering Woods because how else could she be so completely *stupid?*

"Pathetic," Shadow Weaver's voice drips with disgust. "You're still trying to protect her. Did you think you could keep the truth from me?"

For all her apparent bravado, Catra's voice still stutters as she tries to regain control of the situation. "It's just a phase, she's confused. I'll bring her back in, I swear."

"Look at you, stammering like a child." Shadow Weaver turns the monitor off. "You are nothing without Adora. You don't know how to lead, you never did. Adora was the one with power and yes, you will bring her back. Because until I tell you otherwise, that is your mission."

She shrinks slightly, the room brightening almost imperceptibly as the shadows are withdrawn before drifting to the door. She glances back at Catra and the mask does nothing to hide her disappointment.

"And to ensure success, no matter where Adora goes, no matter how long it takes, my shadow spies will find her."

The door slams shut and Catra is left alone again.

Nights are harder than she will admit. She lays in her new bed in her own room – Force Captain privilege – and hears the old melody echoing throughout her head. It's been so long since she slept by herself but she doesn't need anyone to help her sleep, she doesn't *miss* Adora, she isn't lonely –

She pulls the pillow over her ears in an attempt to block out the song, eventually drifting off into an uneasy sleep.

A few weeks later, she is paired up with Force Captain Scorpia who bombards her with hugs and questions.

So many questions. Catra finds herself answering some just in the hopes that she'll stop asking.

Until she starts asking about Adora.

Catra shuts down, answering only in snarling sarcasm. It doesn't deter Scorpia though and it's not until they are sailing away from a failed attempt to take the Sea Gate at Salineas, when they are quite literally floating on the wreckage of their ship that Scorpia asks, "are you okay?" in a way that hints she is asking at something deeper.

"It hurts," Catra finds herself admitting. "She was my best friend."

Scorpia looks sadly at her, "yeah, well it looks like she kind of strung you along there for a long time and that's going to hurt, being pulled against the grain like that."

Catra doesn't respond and they float in silence, managing to make it back to the Fright Zone in one piece. She lies awake that night thinking about the mission and seeing Adora surrounded by those strangers, those *princesses* , looking like she has belonged to them her entire life.

It is so hard to fall asleep by herself.

…….

There are many things Catra cannot believe as she is escorted into the frozen ballroom. First, that she is here, at a ball for *princesses* , of all places and that she is here with Scorpia of all people. She can't believe the food, piled carelessly high on a table and looking infinitely more appealing than any ration bar she's ever eaten. She can't believe the *people,* swirling gowns and soft smiles, everyone looking clean and excited to be here. Catra has never seen so much happiness in one place and it unnerves her.

She can, however, believe that the suit looks good on her. Like, *really* good.

They make their way through the ballroom, arms linked and Scorpia muttering the plan to herself under her breath.

"Relax," Catra smirks. "Look at them, dancing and stuffing their faces. This'll be a piece of cake."

"I don't doubt your plan!" Scorpia chirps. "I just don't want to let you down."

Catra feels a sickening swoop in her stomach. Scorpia is always saying things like that and it…it feels *wrong* to Catra. It feels like a betrayal somehow but Catra doesn't know who she is betraying.

Well…she pushes the thought away. You can't betray someone who is your enemy.

Rolling her shoulders back, Catra scans the ballroom. Her eyes flick up to the balcony where they land on Adora, looking ridiculously good in a red dress but Catra pointedly ignores how her breath catches in her throat at the sight. She is deep in conversation with a girl who looks every bit like the kind of princess Catra and Adora would have made jokes about in the Horde. Pink and purple and *sparkly* and Catra almost finds herself turning to the side to make such a joke.

The realization that it's not Adora by her side still sends an ache through Catra's chest.

She glances back up at the balcony, where the sparkly princess is bouncing up and down as she talks. Adora is smiling and nodding at whatever is being said but Catra notes the tension in her shoulders, the way her hands are fluttering, endlessly straightening and smoothing her dress. She's nervous and, judging by the dark circles under her eyes, tired. If Catra had to guess, Adora was probably up all night drafting tactical strategies, making a war plan of the ballroom going over them repeatedly until she could go through it without a single mistake. Adora could

never do anything without a plan, written and reviewed to perfection.

Except, apparently, leave her home and abandon Catra.

She lets Scorpia pull her away and tries to lose herself in the plan, flitting around the ballroom in an attempt to lead Adora away from her friends and give Scorpia and the rest of their team time to catch up. Eventually, she finds herself on the dance floor, couples surging towards her as the first dance of the ball is announced. She steps back, intending to watch the dancing from a safe distance, when her eyes land on Adora, whose growing panic is all too obvious to Catra as she is surrounded by dancing couples.

It's an opportunity to keep Adora distracted while Scorpia carries out the final part of the plan, that's all. It is not because she likes dancing or because she is enjoying herself or because of the barely masked relief that flickers across Adora's face as Catra comes up beside her, hand outstretched.

Catra can't help but think this is the closest they have been since Adora left. Her familiar scent is muted under something floral and it makes Catra's nose itch. She keeps up a steady banter, ignoring the way Adora's hand feels in hers and the way they dance around each other with ease. The music sounds faint to Catra, another older melody in her head overlapping with the one coming from the speakers.

There is a part of her that wonders if Adora hears it too.

The plan is carried out flawlessly and Catra watches the realization click in Adora's eyes followed immediately by a look of resigned betrayal.

She ignores the slight sting she feels at the look and makes her way to the ship. Adora follows her to a ledge and they are evenly matched until the ground shakes beneath them, knocking them

off the cliff. Adora grabs Catra's hand, slamming her hairpiece into the ice to stop their descent.

"I can get us out of this," she promises.

"Oh, Adora." Catra's ears pick up on the familiar whine of a ship beneath her. "I don't want you to."

She lets go of Adora's hand, hearing her cry out as she falls through the clouds, praying Scorpia's ship has risen in the few seconds she's fallen.

The ship catches her as she knew it would, Adora's friends already tied up in the back, glaring at Catra. She struts past them, over to the window watching as the ship continues rising against the side of the cliff. She sees Adora still hanging there, watches her face crumple as she takes in the scene before her. An unpleasant feeling curls in Catra forcing her to turn away from the window. She crosses the bridge to her seat and sits with her back to the window, not letting herself think about the look on Adora's face. The ship turns slightly, pointing towards the Fright Zone as it flies on.

Catra doesn't let herself look back once.

…….

The castle is *weird* although Catra supposes she should expect nothing less from an ancient ruin that sent up a beam of light a mile high. She can hear Adora's footsteps echoing ahead, her own steps landing silently on the stone floor as she follows the corridor to an open room with a raised platform in the middle. Large crystal pillars stretch up, appearing endless as they disappear into the shadowy ceiling.

Slowly, she circles the room examining the markings and tech that are imbedded in the wall. She moves quietly, catching snippets of Adora's conversation with some hologram lady – who gives Catra the creeps if she's honest – hearing her voice rise in frustration

when the hologram refuses to cooperate and give Adora the answer she wants.

Typical, Catra thinks, leaning closer to a crumbling half-pillar, its top worn smooth with age. The minute something isn't handed to Adora, the minute she can't order someone around, she falls apart.

She examines the small crystal set into the pillar, its edges glowing faintly pink. It looks exactly like the kind of First Ones tech Entrapta had described to her in the Fright Zone – a data crystal she called it. Hooking one claw underneath, Catra pops the crystal off the pillar with a slight *ping* . The light in the room suddenly changes, the soft glow becoming a threatening shade of red and her ears prick up as a rushing sound fills the air. Catra turns and ducks, narrowly avoiding a blast from Adora's sword.

"Hey!" she yells. "Watch it!"

Adora's expression, a fierce look Catra recognizes from every training session, shifts into confusion as she realizes who she just attacked.

"Catra? What are you doing here?"

"Unauthorized presence detected." The hologram lady hums with energy, surrounded by the same red glow, her monotone voice sounding significantly more menacing than it did before. "Security protocol activated."

She disappears and the only light in the room comes from the red glow of the crystals. Adora grabs Catra's hand and yanks her towards one of the doors that hasn't slid shut yet. A chilling screech sends them skittering to a stop as too many sets of glowing red eyes appear in the darkness beyond the door.

"What are those?" Catra feels her chest grow hot as she and Adora turn, sprinting in the opposite direction.

“Not good!” Adora cries which is the only answer Catra really needs.

They flee into a hallway, Adora slamming one of the doors down behind them. It’s the wrong hallway, more glowing eyes – eight eyes to match the eight mechanical legs now appearing out of the dark – approach them, the screeching noise making Catra’s ears hurt.

“Can’t you tell them to stop?” she snaps.

“No, I can’t tell them to stop!” Adora glares at her. “Clearly *nothing* in here is listening to me!”

Catra ignores the jab, the burning feeling spreading down her arms and she is so grateful for the dim light making it impossible for Adora to see her hands tremble. They fling themselves around a corner only to find a dead-end. The spiders round the corner, clicking and dripping a disgusting looking goo all over the floor.

“Adora?” The unmistakable tremble in her voice, the way she immediately looked to Adora to protect her, to get them out of this, fills Catra with suffocating anger.

That anger only grows as Adora *does* get them out of it, swinging her sword in a huge arc causing chunks of rocks to tumble down and crush the spiders. They would’ve been crushed too had Adora not pulled Catra close, her sword transforming into a shield – because *of course* it could – protecting them from the falling rocks.

You shouldn’t be here Catra.” Adora says once the dust settles. “Those things aren’t going to stop until they get you, and as long as I’m protecting you, they’ll see me as a threat too.”

The burning panic has faded but the anger is still there, simmering in Catra’s stomach as she rolls her eyes at Adora. “Uh, good thing I didn’t ask you to protect me.”

But she *did,* didn't she? She looked to Adora, said her name when she was scared and that's the only permission Adora ever needs to step in and take control, never letting anyone even *attempt* to help themselves first.

"Anyway, what are *you* doing here?" Some of Catra's anger leaks into her voice as she asks, "where are your new best friends? I thought you guys did everything together."

Adora scoffs, "oh, my friends?" She crosses her arms and stares at Catra accusingly. "You mean the ones you kidnapped and held for ransom? The ones you let Shadow Weaver imprison and curse"

"Yeah, obviously," Catra says, keeping her voice carefully disinterested. "What other friends would I be talking about?"

Adora turns away, the action stinging more than Catra wants it to. She expected Adora to be angry at Shadow Weaver – she always cared more about her friends' pain than her own. But she didn't expect her to completely miss the point either – that Shadow Weaver did all those things to Catra too and it wasn't enough for Adora. She feels something heavy sink in her chest as she forces herself to accept that Adora never really cared about her.

"C'mon," Adora says without turning around. "We need to get out of here."

The castle only gets weirder as they discover it can project memories and they glitch between their older and younger selves, the line between memory and reality blurring so completely, Catra has trouble keeping them separate.

"Can I ask you something?" Adora eventually asks.

Catra groans, "can I stop you?"

They enter a new room and have to quickly backtrack in order to avoid a cavernous hole in the floor, a fallen pillar stretching across to the other side. Catra leaps up and begins picking her way across.

"Why did you help me escape after Shadow Weaver captured us in the Fright Zone?" She hears Adora climb onto the pillar behind her but doesn't turn around. "It's the one thing I can't figure out. You didn't have to do that. You could've gotten caught…why risk it?"

It's the one thing Catra can't figure out either. It would've been so easy to hand Adora and her friends over to Hordak, so why did she give them a chance to escape? Was it to make Shadow Weaver look bad? If the prisoners escaped right under her nose, that would only increase Catra's favor with Hordak but there were other ways to rise to the top that didn't carry the risk of getting caught. Was it to give herself a chance to win on her own terms, to prove herself by letting them go only to catch them again after they watch her destroy everything they cared about in battle?

Was it just the fear that if Shadow Weaver really took Adora's memories, Catra wouldn't have any reason to try anymore? If Adora didn't remember her, what would be the point of trying to prove how much the Horde is capable of, how much Catra is capable of, in the hopes that Adora would see she had to come back? That she could have so much more power if she just *stayed?*

"It wasn't all bad growing up in the Fright Zone, was it?" she asks softly. "I mean, you still have some good memories right?"

Adora sighs but her voice is genuine and kind, "of course I do! But it doesn't change the fact that the Horde is evil. I had no choice. I couldn't go back."

She gently nudges Catra with her shoulder, "hey…I miss you too."

Heat rushes to Catra's cheeks. "I don't miss you," she scoffs, because it's true and the only reason she still has trouble sleeping is because her room is right next to the Forge, machines creaking at all hours of the night. "Get over yourself!"

“Not until you admit you like me!” Adora smirks, trapping Catra in a headlock that she breaks out of easily. She pushes her away and has to swallow back a peal of laughter as Adora giggles, attempting to regain her balance and aim another playful shove at Catra.

She’s still laughing as she steps back into the wall, passing through with a yelp of surprise as the panel glitches. Catra follows her through into another memory simulation. She finds herself in their old locker room, her younger self furiously wiping away tears of frustration after yet another training session where Adora was flawless and Catra was faulty. She looks in the mirror only to find her current self is staring back.

She blinks and eight glowing eyes replace her reflection. Yelling, she jerks back but not fast enough and the spider manages to grab her, wrapping her in the goo that turns out to be incredibly sticky. It pulls her through the mirror, the simulation dissolving into one of the castle’s many corridors. Catra screams, calling for Adora who appears just as the mirror fades, watching helplessly as the spider drags her away.

Her whole body is burning with panic as she thrashes, the spider never once breaking its stride. Anger burns through her as well as she realizes she once again expected Adora to save her and suddenly the anger is so bright, burning hotter than the fear. Catra unsheathes her claws and slashes at the goo, launching herself at the spider the moment she is free. She rips it apart, her claws shredding the metal like it was paper.

She has it, ready to deliver the final blow when Adora swoops in out of nowhere, stabbing the spider with her sword. It’s screeching stops, the glow fading from its eyes as it falls to its side.

Adora looks up, breathing heavily, “are you okay?”

“I had it,” Catra growls, the anger returning as Adora brushes some of the goo off her shoulder.

“Sure you did,” Adora says offhandedly. “We need to make sure we stay together from now on.”

“Will you stop telling me what to do?”

Adora takes a small step back, “what is your problem? I was just trying to save you.”

That is exactly the problem and Catra can’t believe Adora doesn’t realize it. She didn’t *need* to be saved, she was doing fine on her own. More than that, she had been doing *better* on her own. She turns and storms away from Adora.

“Catra wait,” Adora grabs her arm and Catra hates that she doesn’t pull away. “I’m sorry for leaving…but I never wanted to leave *you!”*

She steps closer, her voice pleading, “You could join the Rebellion! I know you’re not a bad person, Catra. You don’t belong with the Horde.”

But why does Catra have to be the one to leave everything behind? Why does she always have to drop everything for Adora and now, when she is so close to getting everything she wants? Catra *wants* to belong with the Horde. She has power in the Horde, she has respect and she wants everything to go the way she had planned.

A wind blows, opening another door into the Fright Zone. Catra sighs, crossing her arms and she and Adora step forward.

“Let’s just get this over with,” she says tiredly.

Heavy dread washes over her as the memory starts. The Black Garnet chamber and Adora getting them caught but it is Catra who takes the fall.

It is always Catra.

"I've kept you around this long because *Adora* was fond of you, but if you *ever* do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself" Shadow Weaver is saying and Catra can feel the chill of her magic, the hatred and fear from her words stretching across the years.

"She didn't mean to!" Adora's younger self pleads with Shadow Weaver, seemingly unaware that she just allowed all the blame to remain on Catra's shoulders.

The frustration, the anger, and the hurt that have been swirling inside Catra this whole time come to a boiling point. She glitches between her past and present self as she breaks, rounding on Adora, who is already getting defensive.

"I was only trying to protect you!"

"You *never* protected me!" Catra screams. "Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side!"

As she says it, something releases inside her. A floodgate of frustration and resentment that has been building for as long as Catra can remember, opens and she throws it all at Adora.

"When you left, who do you think took the fall for you?" She steps closer, prodding Adora with her finger, blinking rapidly to keep the tears from falling. "Who was protecting me then?"

She doesn't expect Adora to give her a fair answer because the truth was that *no one* had ever protected Catra. When she left, Catra started protecting herself and look at how much she has accomplished. A Force Captain, appointed by Lord Hordak himself who, in only a few short months, was on track to replace Shadow Weaver as second in command of the Horde.

"I'm not afraid of Shadow Weaver anymore," Catra says, anger punctuating each word. "And I'm a better Force Captain than you would've ever been."

Adora's eyes fill with tears and Catra feels a hot swoop of regret in her stomach that she ignores.

"Why do you think I gave the sword back to you in the Fright Zone? I didn't *want* you to come back, Adora!"

She leaves Adora there, refusing to turn around even as she hears the familiar screech of a spider behind her. Adora would be fine, she always was.

Catra picks up speed, running through a corridor of memory simulations, each one a moment where someone doubted her, someone hated her, made her feel small and useless.

Catra is tired of feeling small.

Her ears pick up on another sound, hidden beneath all the voices. It's the song, the same stupid song she used to sing to Adora and Catra wants to cover her ears like a child at the sound of it.

Something Scorpia said comes back to her, about how she was pulled against the grain for so long.

But pulled against the grain, I feel a little pain, that I would rather do without.

The line floats quietly through Catra's brain almost lost in all the echoes and she knows without singing it that it would fit perfectly with the melody the way the first line did.

The simulation shifts and Catra finds herself standing in the doorway of their old barracks. She watches their younger selves cling together, each a life raft for the other.

The only safe place in the Fright Zone was always the one where they were together.

Catra remembers this moment, remembers the promise Adora makes – that nothing bad could happen as long as they were together.

But Adora was wrong, bad things only happened to Catra when they were together. She makes up her mind there and goes back to find Adora, nearly overwhelmed by spiders.

It's almost too perfect.

By the time Catra has destroyed all the spiders, Adora is dangling from a ledge, a thin trail of goo keeping her from falling. She looks up at Catra expectantly, hopefully.

"Hey, Adora," she says, picking up the sword and running her finger along the edge. She moves slowly watching the hope on Adora's face fade into anguish.

"It all makes sense now. You've always been the one holding me back. You wanted me to think I needed you." She crouches down in front of Adora. "Every hero needs a sidekick, right?"

Adora shakes her head desperately, "Catra, no that's not –"

Catra cuts her off with a laugh. "The sad thing is, I've spent all this time hoping you'd come back to the Horde when really you leaving was the best thing that ever happened to me."

She rests the tip of the sword against the goo, tilting her head in thought. "I wonder what I could've been if I had gotten rid of you sooner…"

She cuts the goo and Adora falls, catching a rock a few feet down.

"I-I'm sorry! I never meant to make you feel like you were second best!" She cries but Catra doesn't let herself look down. Instead, she tosses the sword over the ledge, hearing it clank against the rocks as it falls into the darkness.

"Bye, Adora," Catra calls over her shoulder. "I really am going to miss you."

She walks away, the room glitching into darkness around her. All of her anger has dissipated, leaving only a cold feeling in her stomach. It's not until she returns to the Fright Zone that she is able to identify it – guilt.

Entrapta is ecstatic when Catra hands her the data crystal, skittering off immediately to run one of her weird little experiments. Catra turns, intending to leave when she hears Scorpia from across the room.

"I knew Catra could do it! She is the best friend *ever* !"

Catra freezes in the doorway, the guilt threatening to choke her.

"Just keep it down," she orders softly. "I'm going to bed."

.....

She was supposed to *win.*

Catra had played the game and she had played it *well* . She had learned from the best after all. In a little over a year, Catra had replaced Shadow Weaver as Hordak's second in command, gotten the sorceress thrown into prison and was respected and feared across the Fright Zone. She was going to get everything she ever wanted.

Then, Shadow Weaver vanished and with her went any chance of Catra making it to the top.

Maybe she shouldn't have lied to Hordak. Maybe she should have told him Shadow Weaver tricked her. She could've spun it in a way that made her old mentor look even worse – it wouldn't have been hard or really even entirely untrue. If there's one thing Catra can do it's bring out the worst in people.

"You lied to me," Hordak is saying now, staring down from his throne.

“Wait,” Catra frantically tries to think of something, some story she can tell to buy herself enough time to get out of this. Her thoughts are fracturing, crashing into each other so quickly she can’t separate them into coherent ideas.

Hordak pulls the switch, a whine filling the air and Catra gasps as the air is pulled out of her lungs. “I know your lax security allowed Shadow Weaver to escape. I know you’ve been covering it up, lying about her whereabouts.”

She falls to her knees, her vision growing dark at the edges. Hordak crouches in front of her, fixing her with a look of utmost contempt.

“But worst of all,” his voice is almost lost to the whining of the machine. “I gave you the chance to come clean, to prove your worth to me, to the Horde. This was a test.”

Catra doesn’t think the whining actually changes, it’s probably just her oxygen starved brain losing its ability to correctly perceive the world around her. She falls to her side as the whining changes to a humming that sounds eerily like the song from her childhood.

“And you *failed.”*

Hordak’s face swims in front of her, the rest of the room lost to shadows. Catra curls in on herself not sure if she is trying to keep the last of the air in her lungs or the melody out of her head and waits for the end.

It never comes. Catra wakes sometime later in one of the Fright Zone’s many prison cells wondering if this was a better fate than the one she was seemingly doomed for. Scorpia arrives with a plan to break Catra out but she refuses to leave. It doesn’t matter where she goes, she’ll always be a failure.

“I don’t get to win,” she tells Scorpia.

She is dragged in front of Hordak again, this time with the entire Horde as an audience. He berates her, calls her worthless in front

of all her peers, uses her as an example.

"Take a lesson from this," he is saying now. "This is what happens to failures."

Longing flickers briefly through Catra. It takes her a minute to place it but she realizes she wants Adora here with her. Adora had always been able to avoid any real punishment, she would've been able to talk them out of this.

The longing cools, hardens into something that sends a familiar ache through Catra's chest as she remembers how Adora let everyone around them punish her their whole lives, never protecting Catra in any way that actually mattered. The ache swells and she actually glances down, expecting to see a tear in her chest.

Even though it had been over a year since Adora left, the wound was still there, bloody and raw and buried underneath the layers of arrogance and confidence Catra had stolen over time. Arrogance and confidence she draws on now, taunting Hordak, using his own words against him.

"You're the failure," she says, relishing in the gasp that comes from the crowd of onlookers. Fear is the only currency in the Fright Zone, the only way to gain power, and if Catra can use that fear against Hordak well, it'll be obvious to everyone who is really in charge. "You need me just like you needed Shadow Weaver, because you have no idea how to run this place."

Hordak's face is livid, a low growl coming from his throat but Catra doesn't stop. If this is her last stand, she'll be damned if she doesn't take as many people down with her as she can.

"All you know how to do is hide in your lab. Maybe that's why you can't defeat a group of *teenagers* !" The crowd shifts nervously, waiting for Hordak's reaction.

When it comes, it catches them all by surprise. Catra is ordered to collect First One's tech for the Horde, a clear demotion from her

current responsibilities, sure but nowhere near the level of punishment she had been expecting. Until she hears where she is being sent.

"The Crimson Waste?" Catra's tail flicks in confusion. "But it's a total dead zone. Nothing survives out there."

Hordak laughs, a chilling sound that makes Catra shiver. "Exactly."

That's when she gets it, ears pressing flat against her head. She is being sent to look for First One's tech, yes.

But she is not expected to bring any back.

…….

Catra had always been taught that the Crimson Waste was a dead zone, the place you sent the mistakes you didn't want to look at anymore. A slower death than Beast Island some thought but a death sentence all the same. But standing here, in the middle of this thing called a party, surrounded by people toasting her, cheering for her, believing in her, well…Catra has never felt stronger, more powerful, more alive.

Maybe that's why she's raising a glass to Scorpia now, laughing at her jokes, letting her see a side of herself she never would have allowed in the Fright Zone. Maybe a side that didn't exist at all in the Fright Zone.

A breeze blows through the tavern, carrying a whisper that sounds too much like Adora's voice answering a question Catra wished she never asked. *Free?* Is this what it could've been? If things had been different, if Adora had come back, would it be the two of them celebrating here now? Would Catra be laughing at Adora's jokes, raising a glass to her partner, her best friend?

Something cold settles in Catra's stomach and she takes a large gulp of her drink. Turning to Scorpia beside her she says, "when we go back, there's going to be a lot more parties."

“Uh, the crazy desert lady got away,” Scorpia rubs one claw through her hair, glancing at Catra cautiously.

Once upon a time, Catra would’ve thought that any kind of failure was enough to overshadow even the grandest of achievements. Now, with Adora tied up and She-Ra’s sword at her hip, Catra knows she has achieved more than could ever be lost by some crazy desert lady and a princess escaping. It takes her a moment to recognize the feeling – pride. Has anyone ever been proud of her before? Has she ever been proud of herself?

“Let her,” Catra waves her hand in front of Scorpia. “We’ve got the most important thing right here,” she adds, patting the sword at her hip. “You heard that hologram. This is the key to the whole planet.”

The noise in the tavern swells as another round of drinks are passed around and Catra finds herself swept up in the giddiness of it all. Laughing, she grabs Scorpia and pulls her into a room in the back of the tavern. It’s quieter here, the sounds of the party muffled by the metal walls and in the dim light, Catra lets her guard down even more and just talks to Scorpia. She doesn’t think she’s ever just *talked* to her about random, everyday stuff before and it feels nice. It feels almost normal.

“Hey, can I ask you something?” Scorpia eventually says.

Catra shrugs, “sure.”

“Why don’t you sing anymore?”

Catra nearly chokes on her drink. “What?” she asks, voice dangerously calm.

“Lonnie said you used to sing all the time,” Scorpia’s brow furrows. “Seemed kind of annoyed by it actually…not that you’re annoying of course!” She looks frantically at Catra, placing a claw on her arm. “I think it’s great! I would love to hear you sing, I bet you’re really good.”

Catra stares at Scorpia's claw for several moments, her heartbeat pounding in her ears. As if from very far away, she can hear the beginning of the melody in her head, hear Adora laughing as they struggled to come up with lyrics, hear her shushing her on a skiff flying through the Fright Zone and something clenches inside Catra.

"I don't sing," she growls.

Scorpia, to her credit, drops it.

"So, what's next boss?" she asks after several moments of silence.

Catra holds up the sword, "we take this and Adora back to the Fright Zone. Hordak will see me for what I'm worth and I'll be back on top."

"Or, you know, counterpoint, we don't go back at all" Scorpia says hesitantly.

"What?" Catra stares at her. "Why wouldn't we go back?"

"Uh…because you hate it there?"

Catra bristles, "I don't."

"Hear me out, okay," Scorpia holds up her claws. "Within like, a day, you've defeated the gangs ruling the Crimson Waste and made yourself their leader."

Catra tries to ignore the pride swelling in her chest as Scorpia continues, "This is the happiest I've ever seen you. Scratch that. This is the first time I've ever seen you happy, period."

She leans forward, "So, why would we go back? Let's stay here. Forget Hordak. Forget Adora."

The bubble of pride suddenly pops and floods Catra's chest with ice. She curls her hands into fists, letting her claws press into her palms.

“Forget all of them!” Scorpia continues, oblivious to the sudden change in Catra’s demeanor. “We could rule the Crimson Waste together, just the two of us. We could, you know, be happy.”

Just the two of us . Catra’s head is spinning and she blinks a few times, willing the room back into focus. Scorpia is watching her carefully, close enough that Catra can see the faint blush across her cheeks even in the dim light.

“I – I don’t –” Catra stammers, suddenly feeling overwhelmed by Scorpia’s presence, her talk of a future for the two of them. It’s too much, too close to how she and Adora used to talk and Scorpia isn’t – Catra doesn’t –

“I have to go check on the prisoner,” she finally manages and sprints away from the party.

She storms to the small storage room where Adora is being kept, furious with Scorpia for ruining everything and furious with herself that after all this time, after everything Adora has done, Catra is still running to her to escape, to feel safe when things get too much.

Adora begins talking the second Catra shoves the door open and for once Catra is grateful that Adora always needs to be the first one to talk because it gives her a chance to smooth her features into something confident and smug, to bring back the bravado that has only ever been an act, a shield from the world around her.

“Well, hello to you too,” Catra crosses her arms. “What can’t I do this time?”

“Hordak is trying to open a portal. He wants to bring the rest of the Horde army through to Etheria. We can’t let that happen.”

There’s something in Adora’s voice that bothers Catra and as much as she tries to ignore it, she realizes Adora is *scared.* It’s been a long time since Catra has seen Adora like this, close to coming undone from panic.

In another lifetime, she would have pressed herself close, humming a song that was just theirs and Adora's breathing would slowly even out until she was calm enough for Catra to help her make a plan for tackling whatever felt too big to face.

Catra blinks, bringing herself back to this lifetime. "How do you know about what Hordak's doing?"

Confusion flickers across Adora's face. "Shadow Weaver told me," she says slowly. "We know all about Hordak's plan."

It catches Catra off guard. "How exactly did Shadow Weaver tell you this?" she demands.

"You didn't know?" Adora's eyes widen and her expression is a little too close to pity for Catra's comfort.

She repeats the question, "how?"

"Catra," Adora's voice softens. "Shadow Weaver is in Bright Moon."

The world shudders to a stop and Catra feels something tear inside her. Shadow Weaver left her for *Adora.* It shouldn't surprise her but she thought…she had thought maybe if she got far enough ahead, Shadow Weaver would see she was *wrong.* She would see that Catra did have power, did have potential and that she would *stay* .

Adora is still talking, still telling Catra what she's supposed to do like always but it sounds so far away that Catra has no trouble turning and walking out of the room.

She passes Scorpia on her way back to the main tavern room, the sounds of the party still echoing in the halls. Catra reads the question on Scorpia's face almost immediately.

"We are going back," she snarls. The shock on Scorpia's face barely even registers as Catra heads into the tavern. She takes one look around the room, everyone's eyes already finding hers.

“We are going to open a portal” she announces. “And we are going to crush them all.”

The crowd cheers. Catra turns away, heading back to the storage room to prepare her prisoner for transport. It didn’t matter what Adora or her dumb princesses did. Catra had won.

The world had ripped everything away from her and she was going to get it all back.

…….

There is a lever and a choice in front of Catra.

Adora is beside her and in so many ways, this is how Catra imagined it would be for the two of them. Side by side, each one watching the other as they changed the world, as they ruled it.

Of course, in those dreams, Adora wasn’t tied up as Catra’s prisoner and she wasn’t looking at her in terror.

In those dreams, Adora wasn’t screaming, begging, *pleading* with Catra and in those dreams, every single cell in Catra’s body isn’t telling her to let go and listen to Adora, her best friend, the girl she –

But if Catra didn’t matter to Adora, if she wasn’t enough for her to stay then Adora won’t be enough for Catra no matter how much she wants her to be.

For the first time in her life, Catra has a way to get what she wants. She wraps her hand around the lever, the metal cold against her skin.

She pulls.

“NO!” Adora shrieks and Catra wonders briefly if she made the right choice before the world is ripped apart in a violent flash of purple light.

.....

It is late, late enough that Catra decides to finally go and wake Adora up so her idiot best friend doesn't miss the entire day. She shakes Adora awake, watching her glance around in confusion as she does.

"Where am I?" she asks. "How did I get here?"

Something flashes purple in the corner of Catra's vision but she doesn't look over. "Uh, you're in your room. Are you okay?"

Adora shakes her head, "I…I'm fine. I was just having a weird dream. There was something I needed to fix…"

Catra rolls her eyes, "of course *you* dream about work. There's nothing to *fix,* Adora. Everything is perfect."

(And it is, it is perfect but there is something cold in Catra's hands even though they are empty.)

The day goes off without a hitch, everyone celebrating Adora's victory in Thaymor and everyone knows Catra was there, that Catra and the rest of their team helped and they are *proud* of them. It's the best day Catra has had in a very long time but she can't help noticing each time Adora jumps, glancing around, her confusion slowly transforming into panic.

"Do you have a concussion or something?" Catra says after Adora nearly walks into a wall looking for a door that isn't there, that has never been there. She grabs Adora's head and examines it. "I know you get hit on the head a lot but I figured your dumb little hair poof would cushion the blow."

(A flash of purple and Catra is surrounded by trees, the beginnings of panic starting to burn through her at the mention of a sword that's nowhere to be seen.)

Catra sees Adora off to her Force Captain debriefing and, what feels like a moment later, finds her in the hallway staring at a wall,

a piece of paper clutched in her hands.

“Adora?” She doesn’t respond. “Adora! What is wrong?”

She gasps and turns around, holding out the piece of paper. “Did you write this?”

“Did I write a blank piece of paper?” Catra asks, looking down at the crumpled sheet in Adora’s hands. “I’m gonna go with no.”

“No, there was something –” Adora yanks the paper back and stares at it. “Something there, I – I think. And then I was running…why was I running?”

Her voice is tight, the paper shaking in her hands. She is panicked and Catra feels helpless, she doesn’t know what to do.

(There was something she used to do, something that always calmed Adora down but she can’t remember what it was.)

(There is a ringing in Catra’s ears and it almost sounds like a song.)

Adora is breaking, stammering about a sword and something she needs to fix.

(The sword is gone, disappearing into a purple flash and there is nothing for Adora to fix because Catra fixed it all. This is how it should have always gone, why can’t Adora just see that?)

They end up on the roof and Catra refuses to admit to herself that she doesn’t remember climbing up either. Adora’s breathing is slightly calmer and Catra feels herself relaxing as well.

“You’re probably right,” Adora admits. “Everything’s fine.”

Catra scoffs, “Of course I’m right. Everything’s perfect. Soon, the two of us are gonna be ruling Etheria together, just like we always planned.

“Is that what you really want? To rule the world?” Adora asks quietly. She looks at her and Catra does not look at the purple flash that rips through the sky.

“I – I mean yeah, obviously…”

(But she knows she doesn’t want to just rule the world, she wants to rule the world *with* Adora and if she can only have one –)

(The choice is so clear, so bright to Catra. The choice is a battered box and an outstretched hand and one that Catra made years and lifetimes ago.)

“Isn’t that what you want too?” she asks, hoping Adora can hear the underlying question.

Adora looks back out over the Fright Zone, hands clenched on the railing. “I don’t know,” she admits. “What if we don’t stay together? What if it all goes wrong?”

The sky rips in two again and Adora flinches, looking frantically around them.

(And she knows, Catra knows what it means but she refuses to follow Adora’s gaze, to see everything she has ever wanted be taken away from her again.)

“Why can’t you see that?!”

“Adora,” Catra says, keeping the fear at bay like she’s spent her whole life doing. “Stay with me, okay?”

(It was a choice; it was always a choice and Adora has a chance to make a new one but she isn’t and something is splintering inside Catra no matter how much she tries to hold the pieces together.)

It has been a second and week in a single flash of purple light and Adora and her team are getting ready to head out to Salineas.

She won't listen to Catra, continuing to insist that everything is wrong, continuing to insist that everything needs to be fixed.

It ends the same way it began with Adora running off and Catra calling after her. She releases the splintering thing inside her, feels it break, feels the sharp ends pierce her from the inside out because Adora was never going to choose her, Adora never wanted her. Catra rewrote the world for them and *still* Adora didn't stay.

They are in the Whispering Woods and Adora is crying, promising "I won't leave you behind again."

"Why can't you just stay?" Catra screams because if Adora leaves again, she'll forget Catra.

(She promised she would come back and she didn't)

"It's not real Catra!"

(It could be.)

"Why did you do it?" Adora is looking at her disappointed and hurt.

(Because you *left* Catra wants to scream)

"I don't know what you're talking about!"

The Woods are crumbling around them, purple light flickering through the cracks.

"This can't be what you wanted Catra!"

Catra's anger is hot and sharp, "I am *never* going to go with you!"

(You wouldn't stay with me.)

The ground is opening up beneath them, the void sending out a blinding purple light. Catra screams as she tackles Adora,

dragging her towards the edge. “You always have to go and ruin it don’t you?”

“Catra look what’s happening!” Adora begs. “You are going to destroy everything.”

“I *don’t care!* ” Catra howls. “I won’t let you win. I’d rather see the whole world end than let that happen!”

She pulls Adora closer to the void. Adora fights every step and part of Catra just wants to let go.

(Let her go.)

Adora cries out and Catra doesn’t think she can break anymore but she does.

(Let her *go.)*

The ground beneath them rumbles and a sliver of purple light appears at their feet. In the second before it opens, Catra makes another choice.

The sliver becomes a crack, becomes a tear, becomes a chasm. Catra falls towards it, Adora falls away.

(Catra pushed her away.)

She can see Adora desperate above her, see her mouth forming words that Catra can’t hear over the rushing of the void below her and the ringing in her ears that Catra remembers now was a song – their song.

Catra lets go and the void swallows her whole.

…….

Catra knows this is not the only lifetime she’s lived in the portal but she can’t remember the rest of them.

Sometimes she is relieved she doesn't have to see what she could've had, to see it all go right when it only ever goes wrong for her. Sometimes she is regretful she doesn't get to know if they ever make it work.

She wonders how many times she's lost, how much she loses in each lifetime. Does it always end like this? With Adora pinned beneath her, Catra telling her it's her fault, that Adora made her like this? A jagged edge, a broken bone never properly set.

Does it always end like this? With Adora pushing her away, promising to fix the world Catra broke, telling her to live with the choice she made as if Catra wouldn't do anything to unmake it?

Does it always end like this? In the Fright Zone where it began, with She-Ra destroying the portal, the hatred on her face directed at Catra who realizes she's never looked at her like that before? Like she can actually see all of Catra's cracks, see the anger and the sadness and fear leaking out, sees every mistake she's ever made and never tried to fix.

Does it always end like this? With Catra being the one to run, to leave Adora behind with her new family, the one she chose, without even a backwards glance?

Does it always end like this?

…….

There are scars from the portal that only Catra can see.

The Horde is winning, taking more ground than ever before, because of her. Everything is going according to plan with Double Trouble and she gets frequent reports from them about the tension within the Rebellion, how it's breaking apart from the inside out. Hordak may think Catra cannot do anything right, that he is the reason the Horde is turning the tide of the war but she knows the most successful plans are the one she has made. She is on top for the first time in her life.

It feels so fragile all the time.

Double Trouble's latest check-in updates her on the growing tensions between Adora and Glimmer.

"'You took things way too far,' 'Did you really think I would hurt him?' 'We're done here' and poof she teleports away!" Double Trouble cackles from the tablet. "It really is some of my finest work."

"Don't get distracted," Catra orders. "We can't afford to have the Rebellion catching on to the Horde's plans."

"Well, *obviously* ," they wave a hand in front of their face. "I'm not an amateur, kitten."

"I want an update same time next week," Catra says shortly, shutting off the tablet. She sinks onto her bed, pressing the heels of her palms to her eyes. In the quietest part of her mind, she wonders – she *hopes* – that maybe the tension between Adora and her new friends will be enough to convince her to come back to the Horde, to Catra. It's been so long since she believed there was even the smallest chance of that happening and she knows even now that it won't. Adora feels a sense of duty towards the Rebellion and Adora's sense of duty has only wavered once in her entire life.

Still…Catra allows herself this one moment of hope before heading back to Hordak's sanctum.

She runs into Scorpia on the way who holds out a damaged recording chip.

"Entrapta's recordings!" She says brightly. "The chip got damaged when I extracted it but hopefully that won't matter!"

"You broke the recordings?" Catra has gone completely numb. "I asked you to do one thing and you *completely* ruined it!"

Throwing the chip aside she rounds on Scorpia who takes a fearful step back. Anger blazes through Catra's chest, her claws sliding out as she steps forward.

"How could you possibly be this *useless?* " she shouts realizing she isn't sure if the question is for Scorpia or herself.

Scorpia's face shutters and her voice is quietly disappointed, "you're a bad friend."

It hits harder than Catra is willing to admit as she watches Scorpia walk away but she shoves her feelings aside and continues to Hordak's sanctum. She arrives and is finally ordered to give the command she has been waiting for.

The attack on Salineas is carried out flawlessly, the sea kingdom falling with ease while the Princesses fight amongst themselves. Catra sits on a ledge overlooking the Sea Gate. She presses her radio one more time, trying to contact Scorpia but all she gets is crackling silence. Cold dread settles over her and she draws her knees to her chest listening to the creaking of the Horde ships in the bay, the crashing of the waves against the sand and the sad, broken whirring of the destroyed Sea Gate. Maybe Catra really is overtired because the sounds begin to blend together into the old melody and she knows it's just in her head but the lines from Crystal Castle float back into her brain all the same.

But pulled against the grain, I feel a little pain, that I would rather do without.

How many times did she think she could do without Scorpia trailing after her, chatting away about whatever was in her head? Only to end up here, alone, at what could be her greatest victory yet.

It is so very lonely at the top.

Something major happens to the planet as Horde Prime finally arrives and Catra can't fully wrap her head around it all. She has never seen the stars before but now they stretch endlessly across

the sky, blotted out by the thousands of ships crawling through the atmosphere. From behind a piece of rubble, she watches a green beam of light teleport Hordak and the sparkly princess, Glimmer up towards the armada of ships and she knows they must be going to Horde Prime.

Catra leaps forward and feels herself be pulled upwards by the beam. She won't lose this chance to prove herself to someone even bigger than Hordak could ever dream to be. Maybe this time, with a whole new army at her disposal, winning will finally feel right.

…….

It's not the eerie, sterile feel of Horde Prime's ship that sets Catra on edge. It's not the mindless clones seeming to appear out of thin air or the pervasive chill that seems to cling to her no matter where she goes. It's the silence, the complete, suffocating silence of space.

Catra has never heard such silence before. Something was always clashing in the Fright Zone, the sounds of metal and machines leaking through the vents at all hours of the day. Catra had learned how to tune it out but still, even in the quietest parts of her home it was never truly silent.

Now, as she wanders the corridors of Prime's ship, the old melody fills Catra's head and for the first time in nearly three years, Catra finds herself wanting to sing, to fill the deafening silence with *something* . But the notes and the words seem to get stuck in her throat and Catra has lost enough pride to be able to admit that maybe she doesn't want to sing it without Adora, that the song is still theirs, twisted and threaded between them in a way that seems impossible to untangle.

She wonders if maybe that's why she begins to seek out Glimmer instead as a way to fill the silence with something that doesn't make her heart ache. Or, maybe, it's like she tells Glimmer, a way to get information, to get ahead with Prime, to help him win. It is

definitely not because she finds herself enjoying Sparkles' company, because she misses having someone to talk to.

Whatever the reason, Catra finds herself drifting into the prisoner's corridor once again, leaning back against Glimmer's door, knees drawn up to her chest knowing the Queen of Bright Moon is mirroring her position on the other side. They swap stories about their lives, their wars, their versions of Adora.

"Did Adora still thrash around and, like, sleep fight?" Glimmer's voice shakes with laughter. "What was that about?"

"She *always* did that! Adora can't even relax when she's asleep," Catra chuckles but she feels a slight twinge in her chest as she does. What nightmares did Adora bring with her to Bright Moon? Were they the same ones that plagued her in the Fright Zone or did they morph, like Catra's did, into monsters with her best friend's face, worlds where they lost in a thousand different ways, worlds where they spent the rest of their lives apart?

She's silent for a moment too long. Glimmer must notice because a note of hesitation creeps into her voice, a question of whether an invisible line has been crossed. "Did Adora ever…sing?"

Catra barks out a laugh, startling herself and Glimmer. "Adora? *Sing?* " She turns in time to see a blush spreading across Glimmer's cheeks, a familiar look of annoyance flashing across her face as she turns away from Catra.

"You don't need to laugh!" She whines. "Sometimes she would…I don't know… *hum* something! Bow and I noticed it when she was nervous." Her voice drops, softens with an undertone of guilt, "I never asked her about it."

Something cold trickles through Catra's veins. She turns back to stare at her knees. "How did it go? The song, I mean."

Glimmer is quiet for a moment before she starts to hum. Something electric shoots through Catra because she recognizes it, *of course* she does. It's the melody, the one from so long ago

and Glimmer doesn't sing it exactly right but it's close enough and it floors Catra. She's up and running before Glimmer even finishes, tearing through the ship, everything moving too fast and too slow at the same time.

There are no vents, or at least none Catra has been able to access, for her to hide in so she runs, choosing corridors at random until she finds herself in a secluded part of the ship, one she's never been in before. Her heart is racing, her thoughts racing even faster. It's not that Adora remembered the melody – why wouldn't she? It's burned into both of them by a childlike need for safety, for familiarity – but she never considered the fact that Adora might still *sing* it.

Catra wraps her arms around herself, trying to slow her breathing. She paces back and forth for hours wondering what Adora remembered when she sang. Did she remember all those nights in the Fright Zone, the two of them pressed together in one or the other's bunk, Catra singing until Adora could take a deep breath, until Catra couldn't feel her heart racing, couldn't hear it slamming in her chest so hard she worried Adora's ribs would crack.

Or had she managed to separate Catra from those memories, untangle the song from between them until it became something only for Adora?

But if that were true, why wouldn't she have told Glimmer about it?

The sound of marching snaps Catra out of her thoughts. Three clones are coming down the corridor and Catra doesn't think this part of the ship is off limits but she doesn't really want to listen to any of Prime's preaching about peace and order in the universe right now so she turns and quickly heads down another corridor away from the clones.

Her feet carry her back to Glimmer's cell. Glimmer is still leaning against the force field that separates her from the rest of the ship. Her head is resting on her knees and Catra wonders if she has

moved at all since their talk earlier. She doesn't move now, as Catra slides to the floor, back against the force field, an echo of their earlier conversation.

"We used to sing that song," Catra begins once it is clear Glimmer won't speak first. "When we were cadets in the Horde. Well, I would sing it."

She curls her tail around her feet, drawing her knees even closer to her chest. "When Adora was scared, when she came back from really hard trainings…I'd hear her thrashing around on her bunk and I would sit with her and just…sing. It – it calmed her down."

Catra hears Glimmer shift on the other side of the force field but she doesn't turn to look. Something has unlocked inside of her and she knows if she doesn't say this all now, she never will. "When we got older – I think it was her idea to add words – it became this sort of joke between us. But still, when she needed it, I would sing it for her. I haven't…" she stops suddenly.

"You haven't sung it since she joined the Rebellion," Glimmer finishes.

Catra nods. "I didn't – I mean I figured she remembered it but I never thought…I never knew she still sang it."

"She never sang it for us," Glimmer says but her tone is gentle, not hurt like she understands that this was beyond her friendship with Adora. "Sometimes, I'm not even sure she realized she was doing it but she would just sort of hum to herself. She always seemed calmer after, steadier."

She sighs, stretching her legs out in front of her as she leans her head back against the force field. "I mean, it's Adora, she thinks she has to hold it together for everyone all the time but…we could tell."

Catra lets out a soft laugh. "Yeah, that's Adora all right."

Glimmer turns her head slightly to glance at Catra over her shoulder. “What are the words? The ones you added when you were little?” The hesitation slips back into her voice, the understanding that she is approaching some line in their conversation.

Catra is silent, counting her heartbeat as it roars in her ears. She gets to twenty before she makes up her mind. Staring at her feet, she takes a deep breath.

“ *I guess I have to face, that in this awful place I shouldn’t show a trace of doubt* .” Her voice is rough from three years of neglect. She feels Glimmer go very still and swallows before continuing.

“ *But pulled against the grain, I feel a little pain, that I would rather do without* .” She stops as the memories of her and Adora in the Crystal Castle come back, the guilt she tried to bury as she left Adora clinging to that ledge. She realizes she’s never sung the second set of lyrics out loud; she’s never had anyone to sing them to and she likes how they sound. She likes how they fit in the melody.

“Is that it?” Glimmer asks when Catra doesn’t go on.

Catra presses her forehead to her knees. “We never finished it,” she murmurs.

“It almost sounds like you are singing about being here, on this ship.”

A moment of silence passes then Catra laughs. “Yeah, it kind of does,” she admits.

Glimmer turns back around, resting her chin on her knees as she pulls them close again. “Thank you,” she whispers.

Without lifting her head, Catra whispers back, “you’re welcome.”

They sit there, back-to-back, in silence as the ship continues to hurtle through the vast expanse of space.

……

Catra is not sure when she decides to help Glimmer escape. There are times when she wracks her brain, sifting through all her conversations with the Queen of Bright Moon, trying to find something either of them said to justify her actions. Maybe it was the dinner, when Glimmer told Prime about the Heart in a desperate attempt to save her Rebellion, to save Adora. Maybe it was hearing that melody, *their* melody – hers and Adora's – after so many years of trying to forget it. Maybe it was the terror – because yes Catra was terrified when she let herself admit it – of Adora coming here, coming for Glimmer and not for her and maybe Catra is doing this so she doesn't have to see Adora play the hero again, doesn't have to listen to her plead with Catra to just come back with her as if it were ever that easy, as if Catra hadn't wanted to say yes, to take Adora's hand every time she reached out.

There are times when she thinks the decision was already made before she even got on this stupid ship in the first place.

In the end, it doesn't matter when she decided it would happen only that it does. Catra is dragged before Horde Prime and taunts him, uses her smugness as a veil for her fear that it didn't work, it wasn't enough, Adora wasn't safe.

"You will *never* get your hands on Adora!" She spits it in Prime's face. Another promise, one Catra intends to keep.

Prime stares at her for a moment and Catra's brazenness vanishes, her fear starting to leak through. "Oh, my child…you're wrong. Everyone has a place in my empire."

He crouches, reaches a hand towards her face and it is all Catra can do to not pull away. "You will be of use to me yet."

She is dragged to the edge of the green pool of liquid. It's a sickening shade, unnatural and sharp compared to the gentle, soothing green of the trees on Etheria. Catra struggles against the

clones holding her but they don't, or maybe can't, react to her scratches, her bites. She is reminded suddenly of the time Glimmer and her friend, Bow, tried to kidnap her and bring her back to Bright Moon. It had been so easy to break out of their hold, a simple lick and Sparkles jerked away like she had been burned. It was funny at the time, almost a game. Now Catra fights back a sob as she is lowered into the pool, liquid burning her feet and legs as she twists and kicks.

"Prime casts out all shadows. Prime casts out all shadows." The clones surrounding the pool maintain a constant chanting as Horde Prime appears at the edge of the pool. Catra is up to her waist, skin on fire, fractured memories racing through her brain. Shadow Weaver's insults, some thinly veiled in praise for Adora, some blunt with only Catra's apparent cockiness as a buffer. The nights she wasn't allowed to eat because she brought down her team's, and by extension Adora's, time in the training sims. The bone rattling pain every time Shadow Weaver used her magic to freeze her in place.

"I did not wish for you to experience pain, Little Sister." Horde Prime looks down on her from the edge. "But if this is the only way for you to know peace then I have no choice."

A jagged scream tears its way up Catra's throat. She's up to her elbows now and the memories keep coming. Entrapta's face when Catra ordered her to be taken to Beast Island, the sinking feeling in her chest when Scorpia left, the burning one when she found out Shadow Weaver was in Bright Moon.

The liquid laps at her chin. Adora leaving and the cracked, jagged thing in her chest when she did. Adora – She-Ra – looking down at Catra in fear, in pity and then finally in anger and in hatred. Adora choosing the Rebellion, choosing She-Ra over her each time and Catra's heart is both broken and breaking as she struggles to keep her head up.

"Is this what you wanted, Little Sister?" Prime looks at her with something like pity.

Yes . Catra thinks because Glimmer is gone and Adora is safe and Catra would do this a thousand more times if it meant that Prime never even got to *think* about Adora again.

"Prime casts out all shadows, PRIME CASTS OUT ALL SHADOWS." The terrifying chant swells, her limbs growing heavy and her vision blurred green.

No. Catra thinks because she is nothing but shadows. What will be left of her when this is over?

Her head goes under and the pain is everywhere. She screams underwater, feels her lungs burning along with the rest of her body.

I want to be free . It's a wild, desperate thought. She will never be free again. It echoes in her head over and over again until it doesn't sound like her voice anymore, until Horde Prime's voice twists its way into her thoughts and it becomes *I made you free.*

Catra sinks to the bottom of the pool, searing pain tearing her apart from the inside out. Her vision darkens, a horrifying numbness erasing the pain and the last thing she remembers is a faraway melody and a child-like laugh.

…….

A constant static fills Catra's ears, the buzzing of ten thousand voices speaking at the same time and her brain is full of quiet thoughts of praise and worship for Horde Prime. She feels calm, at peace for the first time in her life.

There are times when that calmness, that peace, feels an awful lot like emptiness but Catra doesn't need to worry about that. She doesn't need to worry about anything.

The static changes, sharpens. A ship has arrived, the image of it passed through the hive mind until it is shared with all the clones. Catra feels a slight tugging in the back of her mind – she should

know that ship. But the recognition is gone, swept away into the hive mind before she can place it and the tugging calms.

Whispers of an intruder, a girl, a princess trickle through the hive mind next. A princess come to surrender herself and the static surges with reminders of Horde Prime's greatness, his promise to restore the universe to its former glory and balance.

The static spikes once, sharply and in it is a message, summoning Catra to the throne room. Two clones wait for her outside the doors.

"Glory be to Horde Prime" she greets them. They return her bow and escort her inside. Horde Prime is on his throne, a girl standing at his feet. Catra feels a familiar ache at the sight of the girl's blonde ponytail and red jacket.

At first, she thinks this must be some kind of Horde Prime induced hallucination, some way to continuously punish her for the crimes she committed before she was freed. He has put her through them before, to teach her to let go of her past attachments so she may give herself entirely to the hive mind. She knows she deserves it, to be reminded of her pain so that Horde Prime can free her again, again, again and she is happy to serve him, relishes in his power and attention.

She steps forward calmly, "Hello, Adora."

"What did you do to her?" Adora surges forward, reaching out but is stopped by two clones.

There is something strangled in her voice, something emotional, that never existed in previous hallucinations. Something in Catra's mind gives the slightest push but Horde Prime's voice is in her head, reminding her of all the darkness that once existed in her and is now gone. She is saved, she is light and she is free.

She realizes she can't feel her arms.

“Tell her what I’ve done for you” Horde Prime directs her. Catra responds immediately approaching Adora who’s face – her face is broken and full of fury.

The thing in Catra’s mind pushes a little harder.

“Let her go,” the fury fills Adora’s voice now and the buzzing in Catra’s ears swells suddenly, images and voices passing so quickly through the hive mind that Catra can’t pick out anything specific.

The buzzing grows, becoming a whine that Catra slowly realizes is coming from outside her head. Adora winces, crying out as she yanks a radio from her ear. It clatters to the floor and as it does, the hive mind settles and Catra can see clones around the ship move quickly, opening doors and revealing other outsiders. Adora’s friends, moving closer together as the clones approach.

Catra finds this change curious. In past hallucinations, Adora was always alone, it was always just her and Catra. She wonders briefly why Horde Prime decided to change it…unless…

“Let me know when you’re ready to make a deal.” Horde Prime and his clones disappear through a door and a will that is not Catra’s flexes her hands, unsheathing her claws, forces her to step forward, fists raised.

Her movements are fluid, each one planned before the previous punch even lands. They meet their mark and Adora is crying out in pain, a sound that makes the thing her mind shove and throw its entire weight against the voices of the hive mind.

Something inside Catra is screaming at her to stop.

Adora gets inside one of her punches and grabs her arms and maybe Catra doesn’t fight as hard as she should to break free.

“I am not leaving without you,” Adora enunciates each word so they are impossible to miss even with the static growing in Catra’s ears again.

How many times has Horde Prime put her through this fight? How many times has he made her listen to Adora saying the opposite of what she is saying now? She knows it's not real, knows it's only a punishment and yet…

Catra feels Horde Prime take over inside her mind, hears his words in her voice, "how long will you drag this out? You will destroy the ones you love in the process."

They've made it to the edge of the platform, Horde Prime's will allowing Catra to overpower Adora but it is Catra's hesitation that stops her from letting go as she dangles Adora over the ledge.

Horde Prime's will pushes against hers and when she speaks, his voice is layered on hers. "She was afraid, in the end. And she suffered." Adora's face crumples and she twists, grabbing on to Catra's arm.

"Perhaps I will make her my *new* vessel though she would not last me long. What do you think, Adora?" Catra feels her face split into a grin and watches Adora's pull together in determination. She screams and shoves Catra backwards, away from the ledge and into the monitors in the center of the platform.

She feels the monitors crack, hears a sparking noise as a shock runs through her whole body. It rips her away from the hive mind and for the shortest second, she can take a deep breath, her limbs suddenly heavy with feeling again.

Horde Prime's control slips but Adora doesn't fade away and with a rush, Catra realizes she is actually here. Adora came back for *her.*

She can feel Prime's will rising against her own and the heaviness fades from her limbs, replaced by a horrible lightness, an emptiness as he takes control again.

"You cannot stop Horde Prime!" Her voice is not her own anymore. "He will reign triumphant over all the universe! It is –" A

second crackle of electricity cuts her off, the words becoming an agonized scream.

She falls forward, feeling Adora catch her as the heaviness rushes back. Adora leaps, pulling them away from the collapsing monitors and they land in a heap on the ground. Catra opens her eyes, sees Adora above her and feels her arms holding her tightly so tightly that Catra knows with an aching certainty this is *real* . Adora is real and she is here with Catra now.

"Adora…" her voice is weak and she takes a shaky breath before continuing. "You should have stayed away. Why did you come back? We both know I don't matter…"

Adora begins to cry, her hand coming up to rest on Catra's cheek. "You matter to *me* " she sobs. She says it without a second thought, without hesitation like it was just there in her mind always and Catra can't understand. Catra had never been enough for Adora to stay with her, she never thought she mattered enough for her to come back.

She groans as Horde Prime takes over again but his hold is weak, the heaviness washing over Catra in waves as she struggles to focus on Adora.

Adora who is saying in a choked, desperate voice, "I'm going to take you home!"

The heaviness crashes over Catra and she shudders, wrapping her arms around herself as she realizes how close she is to the edge of the platform. She blinks and feels the tears spill out of her eyes.

"You promise?"

"I *promise* !" Adora reaches out, stretching her hand towards Catra. They are suddenly millions of miles and a lifetime of years away and in their places are two girls, one cowering in a box, one shining bright with her hand outstretched asking if she wants a friend.

Catra feels her own arm reach forward, the image of the two girls dissolving as the throne room and Adora come back into focus.

"Adora," she whispers before Horde Prime takes over once more. He forces her to stumble back and she feels her heels slip off the ledge. The rest of her body follows, plunging down into the endless black beneath the platform.

Horde Prime releases her and Catra's head clears in time to see Adora fling herself over the ledge. She tries to open her mouth but her voice is stolen by the air rushing past and she can't call out, can't tell Adora to stop, that the fall will kill them both and this wasn't supposed to happen, Adora wasn't supposed to come back before she shatters against the floor and everything is gone.

…….

Catra is somehow, impossibly, alive.

She is given a room of her own on Adora's – Mara's – ship and claws at her skin as she attempts to rip the strangling white clone uniform off. She doesn't stop until Adora's hands are wrapped over hers and she goes still while Adora tears the fabric down her back until it is in a pile on the floor and Catra can finally take a deep breath. Adora brings her a pair of grey pajamas that look exactly like the ones they wore in the Horde.

Catra sits on the mattress someone dragged in and stares at them.

"You should sleep," Adora says quietly. "I'll just be outside if…if you need anything."

Catra doesn't answer and after a moment, Adora turns to leave. She pauses in the door and looks back.

"It's going to be okay now," she whispers and Catra can't tell who she is trying to reassure. The door swishes shut and she is alone again.

She stretches one finger out and touches the hem of the grey shirt. The fabric feels exactly like she expected it to, exactly as she remembered. Slowly, her body beginning to ache fully from the events of the past few hours, she pulls the shirt over her head. It smells like Adora and Catra recognizes the floral scent from Princess Prom, but they are faint as if the clothes hadn't been worn recently. Something about it makes tears prick at the corner of Catra's eyes as she pulls on the matching shorts.

They are clearly an extra pair of pajamas Adora packed for her trip to space but Adora didn't bring any pajamas with her when she left the Fright Zone. She didn't bring anything with her, not that they really had anything of their own to bring, which meant that she had them made for her. She could have had anything she wanted and she chose the same pair of pajamas she had slept in her entire life.

Catra blinks, the tears sliding down her cheeks, as she realizes for the first time how *hard* leaving must have actually been for Adora. How lonely she probably was at first to ask for something so inconsequential, so familiar, as her old pajamas. Catra curls in on herself, crying silently until there are no tears left and sleep finally overtakes her.

The days slip by unnumbered. Even if Catra's room had windows it would be impossible to tell where one ends and one begins in the perpetual night of space.

She spends most of her time pacing back and forth trying to sort out the echoes of ten thousand voices that still linger in her head. Occasionally and only once the sounds of the others moving around the ship disappear, she will head to the bridge. Catra likes it here, likes watching the stars race past knowing they are headed back home, to Etheria. The sound of footsteps startles her and she flees soundlessly down the corridor back to her room where she resumes her pacing.

She rarely sleeps and when she does she dreams of hundreds of Catras, eyes shut tight as they hurt everyone. Scorpia. Entrapta.

Glimmer. Adora. All broken and ripped apart in front of her. When she is finally able to scream, the other Catras turn as one and open their eyes, revealing them to be a bright, mindless green.

Catra wakes up feeling like she is burning.

Is it always going to be like this?

She fakes sleep when Adora comes to check on her dreading the look on her face, bright like always and full of relief and hope because she believes everything will be different when they get back. As if they aren't returning to a war where a goal was for both of them to be dead at some point. As if Catra herself hadn't actively tried to bring about the end of days for Adora and everyone she cared about.

Catra can't bear it. Adora had promised to take her home but that was it. She didn't promise to stay with Catra when they got back and she can't handle the thought of being left behind, forgotten, again. So, she retreats, lashing out in the only way she knows how by poking at others and burning the bridges they are trying to build.

"Why do you care?" she screams at Adora. "I know you all hate me!" They must. They must all hate her and they are only being nice, being kind, being *friendly* towards her because they are scared she will hurt them. Again.

"I never hated you!"

It's like being back under Prime's control and Catra can't take a deep breath, can't believe what she is hearing no matter how desperately she wants to. All Catra has ever done is ruin things for Adora.

Held her back.

Distracted her.

And *still* , Adora came back for her.

It’s not until Adora is standing in front of her saying she’ll never have to see her again that Catra finally breaks and lets herself believe that what Adora said is true and asks her to stay while Entrapta removes the chip.

She does and Catra feels threads of hope begin to weave themselves into her thoughts. For the first time, she thinks maybe it will be different when they return home.

Maybe it will be better.

…….

They land on a crumbling Etheria to find the Rebellion hanging on by threads and Catra realizes how much the Rebellion expects Adora to be, how much Adora expects herself to be. She sees it in the way everyone turns to her immediately in meetings, expecting Adora to have the answer. Or, more often than not, expecting She-Ra to be the answer. But Adora isn’t just She-Ra and sometimes Catra feels she is the only person to remember that.

She watches Adora throw herself into the fight without a thought as to what could happen to her and Catra wants to feel angry but all she feels is fear that Adora is going to burn herself up if she doesn’t stop and let people help her. She sits up all night wondering what it would take to convince Adora she doesn’t have to do this alone, that there are people who can help her, people who-

People who love *her* , not what she can do.

The war rages on, a helplessness settling over Catra and she wants to leave, she wants to run away again so badly. She knows she can’t control the outcome of this war in the way that she could before (a thought that chills her more than Shadow Weaver’s magic ever did) but if she fights, if she *stays,* at least she can be there and make sure that Adora knows she mattered too.

“Why do you always have to sacrifice yourself? When do you get to choose?” She asks in a final, desperate attempt to get through to Adora. “What do you want, Adora?”

“I – I have to do this Catra,” she answers, hesitation fading into forced confidence. “I’m the only one who can.”

The helplessness surges over Catra once again as Adora refuses to consider that she may actually *want* something for herself and not because someone told her it was what she should want. It’s all too much for Catra so she turns and leaves, like she has been trying not to do since the moment the ship landed.

Old habits are the hardest to break.

Catra has barely left the Rebellion’s camp when the doubt and regret begin to slide into her thoughts, pushing against the lingering dread that this was only ever going to end one way. She races through the woods wondering if she runs far enough she’ll be able to leave those thoughts behind. One of Prime’s clones appears and curiosity overtakes Catra as she follows them through the woods.

The clone leads her to a probe tower and horror replaces the dread in Catra as she sees what Prime is doing to the planet, what’s coming for Adora.

Stupid, bright, hopeful Adora who always believes she has to be the one to fix everything, that she doesn’t have a purpose outside of other’s need for her. Adora who still sang their childhood song even when Catra wasn’t there to sing it for her and it’s there, hiding from the clones in the shadow of the probe tower, that Catra decides the rest of her life is going to be spent with Adora.

However short that may be.

She turns around, runs straight into Shadow Weaver who tells her she is too late.

“If you are still so selfish as to try and stop her –” Once, a long time ago, this would have been enough to freeze Catra in her place. Now the only thing keeping her from freezing is the panic that has been smoldering in her chest since she stumbled across Prime’s probe in the woods.

“Enough!” Catra roars. “Prime is doing something to the planet. He’s infecting it. He’s going for the Heart.”

Shadow Weaver gazes at her, suddenly seeming so much less imposing than Catra remembered.

“We’d never reach her in time.”

“Use your magic,” Catra counters. “You’ve done it before! And you’ve always been able to track us our whole lives. So, do something good with it and help me save Adora before it’s too late!”

Catra watches as Shadow Weaver slowly pulls out a small jar swirling with purple magic and draws a complicated circle on the ground.

“Come here,” Shadow Weaver extends her hand. Catra takes it and steps into the circle. The magic rushes around them and for a moment, Catra loses control of her panic as she feels herself fading into it. Shadow Weaver’s hand tightens on hers and everything comes back into focus.

They land in front of Bow and Glimmer who tell them Adora has gone off on her own and Catra feels the terror flare inside of her that she has come so far, gotten so close only to lose again.

She doesn’t linger to watch them teleport back to the surface, not wanting to see the hope on their faces that her coming back meant things would end differently. She doesn’t want to be reminded of her and Adora on Mara’s ship, the fragile hope between them that they would get it right when they arrived home.

There has always been a very fine line between hope and heartbreak.

…….

They've nearly reached the Heart when Adora stumbles again, Catra reaching out to catch her without a second thought. They pause for a moment, Adora fighting back another wave of pain.

Prime's virus is taking its toll on her.

Catra can see it, not just in the vivid green streaks that grow larger across Adora's face as they get closer to the Heart, but in the way her breath hitches as she inhales. The slightest crease between her eyes, the smallest indication of the enormous amount of pain crashing through her, the unsteadiness in her steps.

Adora, who had always charged into everything with a certainty Catra spent years trying to replicate, whose steps were now wobbling, a moment of hesitation in between putting one foot down and picking the other up.

They go forward.

Catra suddenly finds herself needing to fill the silence that is stretched out between them. But the words, whatever they should be, are not there and Catra's chest is filling with a familiar frantic heat, the fire she spends so much time trying to douse suddenly blazing as they get closer and closer to the Heart. For the second time in over three years, Catra starts to hum, the familiar melody almost instantly quelling the fire inside her. She feels Adora tense in recognition beside her and her steps imperceptibly become a little steadier.

The melody carries them down the corridor until they reach the chamber where the Heart waits, raw magical energy arcing off it with every pulse. As she reaches the end of the song, Catra glances over at Adora who is looking at the Heart. Three years they've been apart and Catra still knows her, knows how to read

her better than anyone so she should be able to read the expression flickering across Adora's face but she can't.

"Hey" she breathes, placing one hand on Adora's shoulder. The touch shocks her out of her thoughts and she blinks, turning towards Catra, the expression wiped clean and replaced with something broken and sad.

"We never finished it, did we?" Adora asks quietly.

Adora, who everyone always expected to be so big, as big as She-Ra as if that's all she ever had been, ever would be, whose voice is so *small* that something inside Catra cracks. Adora who is looking at Catra like she can only see a thousand fractured promises between them and suddenly Catra is *there* , back on Prime's ship, the swirling green liquid beneath her and a single word, *free* , pounding through her head in time with her heart.

The question hangs unanswered between them as they both turn back towards the Heart. Adora steps forward, determination and resignation written all over her face, Catra right beside her as they cross the chamber to the Heart.

.....

This is how it ends , Catra thinks as she shelters Adora from the fury of the magic above. She doesn't want it to end, she wants it to start over, to go back to the beginning and do so much differently. It's the portal all over again, the frantic need to find a way to get it right only this time there are no purple flashes to remind her that it is all a terrible, wishful dream.

There is only Adora, fading away in her arms and the frantic terror blazing through her that she is about to lose everything she ever wanted. She promises herself, promises Adora that she'll stay and she means it. She won't leave even if this is the end. Catra curls closer, pressing her face to Adora's shoulder as the magical storm grows around them.

It’s only when the whine of the magic changes, becoming balanced rather than a clashing chord that Catra realizes she has been holding her breath.

It’s only when she feels Adora move underneath her, that she releases that breath, feeling herself shudder on the inhale.

It’s only when she tears her gaze away from the shield – She-Ra’s shield – that has appeared above them that she realizes Adora’s eyes are open, bright with life and crinkled in the corners as she smiles at Catra.

It’s only when they move towards each other at the same time that Catra finally feels something cool inside her, the fiery terror burning out completely, replaced by a rush of relief and hope and love.

They have always been two halves of the same broken heart and, surrounded by a soft golden light, they slowly, *finally* , come back together.

…….

Adora is waiting for her, hand outstretched as Catra comes up the hill. She is reminded once again of the bright little girl, the first spot of light she ever saw in the Fright Zone as Adora pulls her close, resting her forehead against Catra’s.

“It’s over” she whispers. “He’s gone.”

“Good riddance,” Catra replies.

We’re free she thinks.

They pass hundreds of parties on their way back to Bright Moon, the interior of the castle surprisingly undamaged despite the beating the outer walls took during Prime’s invasion. Adora leads them to her room, the air stuffy from being closed up for so long.

“Is that a fountain?” Catra asks in disbelief.

“It’s a waterfall,” Adora corrects, smiling.

Catra rolls her eyes, “does it matter?”

“It does for Glimmer.”

“Oh well, anything for Sparkles.”

Adora laughs and sinks into one of the many, *many* , squishy chairs around the room. She leans back, eyes closed and lets out a deep sigh.

Catra glances over from where she had been watching the fountain – waterfall – and feels the world tilt sharply around her. Adora’s position is a little too close to the moment in the Heart that will live like a ghost in Catra’s head for the rest of her life. The bile is rising in her throat as the memory of Adora going horrifyingly still comes back, Catra’s face buried in her shoulder crying don’t you get it, I love you and begging her to stay, stay, *please stay* .

Swallowing, she forces herself to take a step forward, taking Adora’s hand, finding it warm as it squeezes hers. Adora opens her eyes and smiles up at Catra and the world goes still.

“You okay?”

Catra nods and squishes herself on to the chair next to her. They fit together easily, having long since memorized each other’s shape. Catra tucks her head under Adora’s chin, her tail wrapped across her legs as Adora’s arms pull her close.

The weight of everything that has happened presses against them but Catra decides she’s not ready to pick it up just yet.

A purr rumbles in her chest and moments later, she feels Adora’s breathing grow slow and even. Catra can’t remember the last time she slept, the last time she felt as safe as she does now. She snuggles closer to Adora, eyes growing heavy as she drifts off to sleep.

She wakes abruptly sometime later, the room shadowed in blue from the early morning light. A small noise causes her to glance over at Adora, still asleep but her hands are clenched into fists. She makes another noise, louder than the first and Catra reaches over, giving her wrist a reassuring squeeze.

She stays trapped in her nightmare but at Catra's touch, she lashes out and Catra has to let go to avoid being hit.

"Hey," she says, reaching for Adora's shoulder. "Adora."

Adora thrashes around in her sleep and Catra repeats herself, "Adora!"

She sits up with a scream, her eyes flying open as she looks around frantically. Recognition dawns across her face as she takes in the familiar room but she startles slightly when she notices Catra next to her.

"Bad dream," Adora says apologetically. "I'm sorry I woke you."

She settles back against the pillow and lets Catra wrap her arms around the way she did when they were younger. Her breathing is calm but Catra can feel her trembling against her.

"I can sing, if you want me to?" she whispers.

Adora nods and Catra begins to hum. She repeats the song a few times, until Adora has stopped shaking. They lay in silence for a few moments before Catra speaks again.

"Is now a good time to tell you I added some more words?"

Adora pushes herself onto her elbows, "you did?"

"Only a few," Catra nods.

"Can I hear them?"

They sit up, Catra drawing her knees up and wrapping her tail around her feet.

" *I guess I have to face, that in this awful place, I shouldn't show a trace of doubt."* She sings and Adora smiles, remembering.

" *But pulled against the grain, I feel a little pain, that I would rather do without."* Catra clears her throat and looks over at Adora. "That one is from the Crystal Castle. When we…when I…"

Adora rests her hand over Catra's. "it's over now, Catra. It's okay."

She takes a deep breath and continues, " *I'd rather be free."*

" *Free,"* her eyes close as she remembers the way the green liquid burned her skin.

" *Free,* " she digs her claws into her arms, reminding herself she can still feel them

" *Free,"* she finishes, remembering the way the magic rushed from the Heart, Etheria reclaiming itself. *"From here."*

Adora says nothing, waiting for Catra to speak first.

"That's all I could think on Horde Prime's ship." Catra finally whispers. "When he – I just wanted to be free."

Adora squeezes Catra's shoulder and she tilts her head so it rests on Adora's hand. After a moment she says, "I still have nightmares about that."

"You do?" concern fills Adora's voice.

Catra shrugs, "not as bad as when we were in space but…yeah sometimes."

"Why didn't you come get me?"

"I thought…I didn't want your help."

Adora takes her face in her hands and rests her forehead against Catra's. "I wanted to help you, Catra."

"I know," Catra closes her eyes, her hands coming up to cover Adora's. "I'll tell you next time."

"Promise?"

"I promise." Catra knows she will too, not just because she promised but because Adora was right all those years ago.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as they have each other.

End Notes

yikes this was a mess but so am I so ¯_(ツ)_/¯
This was originally supposed to be a very short oneshot of Catra just singing it but I quite literally never know when to stop writing so it sort of spiraled into a character study of my fav catgirl :)
Also, as someone who deeply and painfully relates to and identifies with Adora, this was a really fun challenge for me to explore the other side of their dynamic.

Thank you for reading it! Come yell at me on tumblr (adoras-braincell) if you want!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!